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23 ஏப்ரல்   வாக்களிப்பீர் உதயசூரியன்



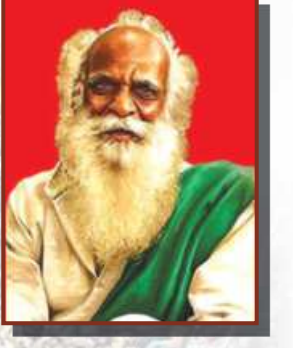


வாக்களிப்பீர் உதயசூரியன்

ஸ்டாலின் தொடரட்டும்.. தமிழ்நாடு வெல்லட்டும்!

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குடிக்க தூய குடிநீர், எரிக்கத் தடையற்ற மின்சாரம்,
பயணிக்கத் தரமான சாலை

சிறந்த கல்வி, கல்விக்கேற்ற வேலை,
வேலைக்கேற்ற சம்பளம் அதைக் கொண்டு
வாழ்கின்ற பெருமைமிக்க வாழ்வு! அதுவே எம் கனவு!

விவசாயி

சின்னத்திற்கு

வாக்களிப்போம்!

வருங்காலத் தலைமுறைக்கு
வாழ்வளிப்போம்!





ELECTORAL MAPPING

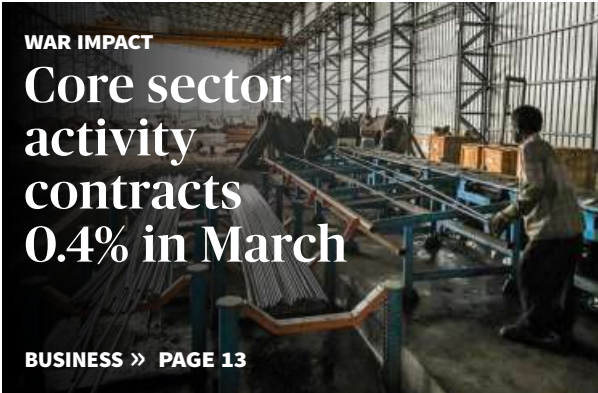
9.8 lakh deletions in Odisha's voter rolls

NEWS » PAGE 10

WAR IMPACT

Core sector activity contracts 0.4% in March

BUSINESS » PAGE 13



STUDY FINDINGS

'Forests could double carbon storage by 2100'

NEWS » PAGE 12



BIG MISMATCH

Vulnerability in India's LPG supply model

Design of system must change to address gaps

EDITORIAL » PAGE 8



THE REVIVAL

Tilak's innings turns things around for MI

SPORT » PAGE 15



Virudhunagar explosion toll increases to 25

VIRUDHUNAGAR
The death toll in the fireworks unit explosion at Kattanarpatti here rose to 25, with two more workers dying of burn injuries early on Monday. Six others, a 12-year-old boy among them , are undergoing treatment. » **PAGE 6**

EPS accuses DMK of trying to break AIADMK, PMK

SALEM
AIADMK chief Edappadi K. Palaniswami on Monday accused the DMK of trying to break the AIADMK and PMK. He added that the ruling party did not succeed in its attempts to break them. » **PAGE 6**

Iran undecided on talks; Trump to keep blockade

Tehran condemns U.S. attack on an Iran-flagged vessel in the Gulf of Oman, says it will make 'necessary decisions about the future path with careful consideration of its national interests'

Stanly Johny

Tehran said on Monday it had yet to decide on joining a new round of peace talks with the United States in Pakistan, citing “bad faith” and “historical mistrust”, while U.S. President Donald Trump said the naval blockade imposed on Iran would remain in place “until a deal is reached”.

“So far we have not made any decision regarding the next round of talks... Iran will make the necessary decisions about the future path with careful consideration of its national interests,” Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmaeil Baqaei said in Tehran, according to Tasnim News Agency.

“From the early days of the ceasefire, we were



Trouble at sea: The Iranian container ship *Touzka* was reportedly attacked by the U.S. Navy on Sunday night. REUTERS

faced with the U.S.'s bad faith, contradictory statements, followed by a naval blockade,” Mr. Baqaei said. Even after an understanding was reached, Iran encountered “maritime actions” in the Strait of Hormuz, he added, referring to a U.S. attack on an Iran-flagged vessel in the

Gulf of Oman on Sunday. In an interview with *The New York Post*, Mr. Trump downplayed Iran's comments, saying he was willing to meet Iranian leaders if a breakthrough is reached. “We are supposed to have talks. So I would assume at this point nobody is playing games,”

he said, adding that Vice-President J.D. Vance, Special Envoy Steve Witkoff, and Jared Kushner, the President's son-in-law, would take part in talks.

Later in the day, Mr. Trump left a series of social media posts claiming that he was winning the war and that the deal his administration was seeking was “better” than the 2015 nuclear agreement reached between Tehran, Obama administration, and other world powers.

“I'm winning [the] war by a lot... The enemy is confused... The blockade, which we will not take off until there is a deal, is absolutely destroying Iran. They are losing \$500 million a day,” he wrote.

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 10**

21 killed as bus rolls down hillside in J&K



Major tragedy: The wreckage of the bus being removed from the accident spot in Udhampur district of J&K on Monday. ANI

Peerzada Ashiq
JAMMU

Twenty-one people were killed and over 61 injured after an overcrowded passenger bus tumbled down a hillside in Udhampur district of Jammu and Kashmir on Monday. The bus crushed an autorickshaw before landing upside down on the road below.

The bus was *en route* to Udhampur from Ramnagar when the accident occurred around 10 a.m. Offi-

cials said those travelling in the autorickshaw were also injured.

The bus driver may have lost control while negotiating a sharp turn in Kagort village, causing the vehicle to plunge off the road, Shiv Kumar Sharma, Deputy Inspector-General of Police, Udhampur-Reasi Range, said. “The bus rolled down around 60-70 feet,” he said.

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 10**

BJP has taken control of AIADMK, says Kejriwal

Aloysius Xavier Lopez
CHENNAI

The BJP has “captured” the AIADMK, and the AIADMK has committed the biggest crime against the people of Tamil Nadu by bringing the BJP to the State, Aam Aadmi Party leader and former Delhi Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal said on Monday.

At an election campaign meeting in the presence of Chief Minister M.K. Stalin in Egmore, he said Mr. Stalin is doing very good work. Almost 1.3 crore women head of family were getting ₹1,000 a month. The Chief Minister's Break-fast Scheme was implemented in schools. When girls passed out of school, they got ₹1,000 a month for higher education. No other State is implementing such schemes, Mr. Kejriwal said.

FULL REPORT ON
» **PAGE 6**

SRI SHANKARA JAYANTI MAHOTSAV

CELEBRATING THE BIRTH ANNIVERSARY OF THE PEERLESS PRECEPTOR

JAGADGURU SRI ADI SHANKARACHARYA

Today, Shankara Jayanti, marking the anniversary of Jagadguru Sri Adi Shankaracharya's birth, is celebrated throughout the world by followers of Sanatana Dharma.

A Legacy Beyond Time

Sanatana Dharma or Hinduism as it is known today, is vibrant today largely due to the efforts of the Avatar of Bhagavan Parameshwara, Jagadguru Sri Adi Shankaracharya the great philosopher saint, who lived over twelve centuries ago. Rarely in history has a single individual shaped the spiritual, cultural, and philosophical fabric of a civilisation so profoundly. Sri Adi Shankaracharya's influence continues to guide millions, inspiring seekers toward knowledge, harmony, and liberation.

KALADY — THE SACRED BIRTHPLACE OF THE JAGADGURU

A Sacred Landmark Rediscovered

Though the life and achievements of Sri Adi Shankaracharya remain eternal, his birthplace had faded from public memory for centuries. It was in the late 19th century that Sri Sacchidananda Shivabhinava Narasimha Bharati Mahaswamiji (33rd Shankaracharya of Sringeri Sharada Peetham) rediscovered Kalady and restored its rightful place in India's spiritual map.

Where History And Divinity Meet

This remarkable rediscovery was made possible through the spiritual insight of the Mahaswamiji, supported by the dedicated efforts of erstwhile rulers, scholars, administrators, historians, and devotees of the time.

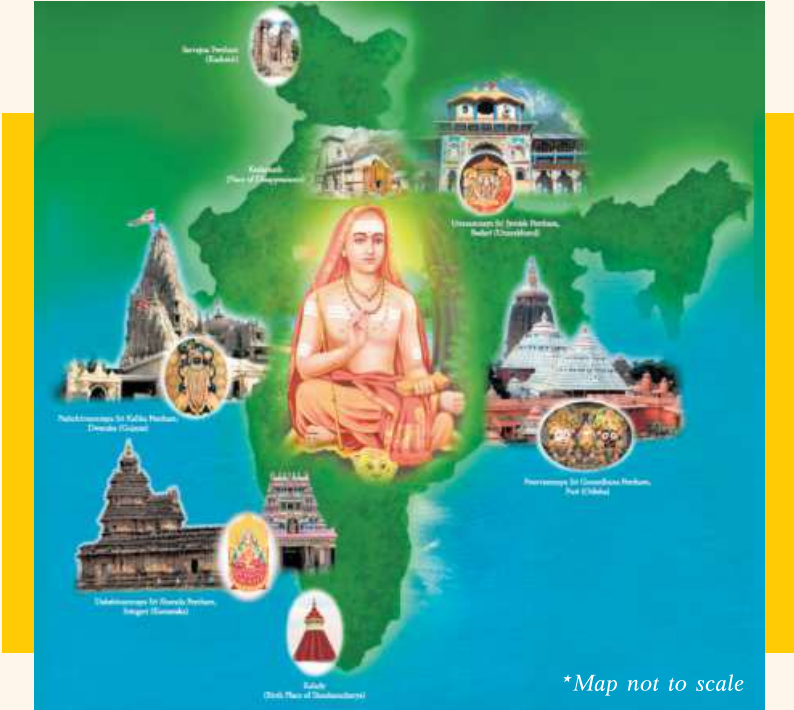
The places associated with the early life of Jagadguru Sri Adi Shankaracharya — from the time of his parents, Aryamba and Shivaguru, to the extraordinary events of his childhood — have been identified in and around Kalady. These findings are rooted in the authentic text Madhaviya Shankara Digvijaya, composed by Sri Vidyaranya Mahaswamiji (12th Shankaracharya of Sringeri Sharada Peetham).

Glimpses Of A Divine Childhood

In accordance with the Namboodiri

VAISHAKHA SHUKLA PANCHAMI

◇ APRIL 21, 2026 ◇



tradition, his mother, Aryamba, who gave birth to Sri Adi Shankaracharya at Kalady, continued to reside there after the passing of Shivaguru. The young Shankara studied at a nearby Gurukula, where he composed the famed Kanakadhara Stotram, blessing a poor household with lasting prosperity — an episode that continues to inspire faith and devotion. The young prodigious

Shankara served his elderly mother and turned away the wealth presented by the Kerala king. It was from his birthplace at Kalady in Kerala that the young Shankara, aged only 8, set out on his remarkable journey to study Vedanta under the eminent Guru, Sri Govinda Bhagavatpadacharya.

NATIONAL & DHARMIC INTEGRATION — SRI ADI SHANKARACHARYA'S TIMELESS VISION

Reconnecting a Diverse Nation Through Spiritual Unity

India's rich spiritual heritage has long encouraged pilgrimage and devotion. Yet, it was the great philosopher-saint Sri Adi Shankaracharya who revitalised this tradition, traveling across the entire nation three times in his 32 year lifetime. His journeys were not merely spiritual — they were a powerful mission to unify the country. With great foresight, Sri Adi Shankaracharya established four

Amnaya Peethams in the four directions of India.

Among these, the Dakshinamnaya Sri Sharada Peetham established at Sringeri has been adorned by an unbroken succession of illustrious Acharyas right from Sri Adi Shankaracharya's direct disciple, Sri Sureshwaracharya. The lives of the Acharyas and their efforts to continue the mission of Sri Adi Shankaracharya are remarkable and unique. Following the guidelines outlined in the Mathamnaya Stotra for a head of the Amnaya Peetham, the Shankaracharyas of the Sringeri Sharada Peetham by their own conduct and by their discourses, teach dharmic tenets, impart Vedantic wisdom and also instill in us the need for paying gratitude to Sri Adi Shankaracharya.

Besides the four Amnaya Peethams, many smaller Shankarite institutions or Shakha Maths came to be established by the later Shankaracharyas starting from Sri Vidyaranya Mahaswamiji (the 12th Sringeri Shankaracharya, renowned for being instrumental in the founding of the Vijayanagar empire).

Reviving Sacred Traditions

During his travels, Jagadguru Sri Adi Shankaracharya restored temple worship and reestablished sacred Murtis in key pilgrimage centres like Badrinath, Jagannath Puri etc. and Srichakra Yantras in Kollur, Kanchipuram etc. At Sringeri, He consecrated Sri Sharadamba, the divinity of Knowledge on a Srichakra and established the southern Amnaya Peetham. Sri Shankaracharya demonstrated the importance of women in our tradition, as evidenced by the appointment of Mandana Mishra's wife, Ubhaya Bharati to adjudicate in the famous debate.

Unity Beyond Regions

To strengthen national integration His actions bridged regional differences and fostered a shared spiritual identity. For instance, He appointed:

- Kerala Nambudiris to serve at Badrinath in the north
- Maharashtra priests, after receiving sacred Deeksha from the Sringeri Shankaracharya, to conduct worship



at Sri Ramanathaswamy Temple in Rameswaram.

- Padmapadacharya from the south as the Peethadhipati of the Dwaraka Peetham in the west.

- Sureshwaracharya from the north as the Peethadhipati of the southern Peetham at Sringeri

The Universal Message

At a time when sectarian conflicts were prevalent, Jagadguru Sri Adi Shankaracharya promoted harmony by reviving the Panchayatana Puja system and worship of six major paths or Shanmata.

The Jagadguru emphasised that true liberation comes from realising Brahman, the ultimate Reality. By transcending divisions and embracing unity, individuals can achieve lasting peace and freedom from suffering.

GRATITUDE TO THE UNIVERSAL PRECEPTOR

Honouring the Tradition that Preserves Timeless Wisdom

Offering gratitude to Jagadguru Sri Adi Shankaracharya was systematised by the remarkable contributions of the 33rd Shankaracharya of Sringeri, Sri Sacchidananda Shivabhinava Narasimha Bharati Mahaswamiji in the late 19th century. He directed that Shankara Jayanti be observed over five days across the world—by Hindus and all admirers of Sri Adi Shankaracharya, transcending boundaries of nationality and religion. Today these celebrations are held not only in Bharat, but also across continents including Europe, Australia, Africa and the Americas.

Under the Mahaswamiji's direction, the complete works of Jagadguru Sri Adi Shankaracharya were first compiled and made accessible, ensuring that

every sincere spiritual seeker can benefit from this timeless wisdom.

SRI SHANKARA JAYANTI 2026 — GRAND CELEBRATIONS

A Sacred Gathering of Devotion, Learning, and Tradition

Dakshinamnaya Sringeri Sharada Peethadheeshwara, Jagadguru Shankaracharya Sri Sri Bharati Tirtha Mahaswamiji and Jagadguru Shankaracharya Sri Sri Vidhushekhara Bharati Mahaswamiji will celebrate the auspicious Sri Shankara Jayanti of the Paraabhava Samvatsara from April 18 to April 21, 2026 at Sringeri. Similarly Kalady, the birth place of Sri Adi Shankaracharya and hundreds of branches of Sringeri and other Amnaya Peethams, various Maths as well as the central and state governments, and various spiritual centres across the world celebrate this day. The celebrations will feature a rich blend of sacred rituals and spiritual discourses, Veda Parayana, Vakyartha Sabha, special Pujas at Sri Adi Shankaracharya temples, Madhaviya Shankara Vijaya Parayana, Purna Arati at the river Poorna, Teppotsava, Rathotsava, grand procession etc.

Devotees, scholars, and spiritual seekers from across the country are invited to participate in this divine celebration — honouring the timeless teachings of Adi Shankaracharya and preserving India's rich spiritual heritage.

Join the celebration. Experience the tradition. Be part of a living legacy.

SRI SRI JAGADGURU SHANKARACHARYA MAHASAMSTHANAM

Dakshinamnaya Sri Sharada Peetham, Sringeri - 577 139.
www.sringeri.net

-Advt.



M CH-CHE



SHRI NARENDRA MODI
Honourable Prime Minister of India



H.E. LEE JAE MYUNG
President of The Republic of Korea

TWO NATIONS. ONE VISION.

A Steel Partnership for the Future.



Mr. Sajjan Jindal,
Chairman, JSW Group

Mr. Chang In-hwa,
Chairman, POSCO Holdings

JSW Steel and POSCO join forces to build a 6 MTPA Integrated Steel Plant in Odisha.

A Landmark 50:50 joint venture between JSW Steel and POSCO, two of the world's leading steelmakers.

High-grade flat steel for diverse applications including automotive, serving India and the world.

ALIGNED WITH AATMANIRBHAR BHARAT

Strengthening India's Steel ecosystem and supporting the nation's industrial value chain.

From Congress dominance to Dravidian duopoly

■ DMK - 137 ■ Congress - 51 ■ Swatantra - 20
■ CPI(M) - 11 ■ others - 15

Yet again, the State faced Assembly election earlier than the normal, as the DMK regime was dismissed on the ground that the State government had abetted the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE) that had attempted to use Tamil Nadu as a base for its activities. As the poll campaign was in progress, former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi was assassinated by LTTE members at a rally in Sriperumpudur on the night of May 21. The results were heavily loaded in favour of the AIADMK-Congress coalition and Jayalalitha became Chief Minister for the first time.

— With inputs from
Areena Arora & Nitika Francis
(Data for the maps sourced from Election
Commission Of India & Lok Dhaba)

INBRIEF



Passenger satisfaction survey for Metro Rail gets under way

Customer satisfaction survey for the Chennai Metro Rail system, conducted by the Community of Metros (COMET), a global urban railway benchmarking group of the Transport Strategy Centre (TSC) at the Imperial College London, has been on. The survey is held for several Metro Rail systems across the world, including Delhi Metro Rail, Bengaluru Metro Rail, and Chennai Metro Rail systems, to know the ease of commuting in such mass rapid transit networks. In Chennai, the online survey began on April 13 and will go on till May 10. People can participate in the survey via Chennai Metro Rail's website or on social media platforms such as X.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (April 21, Tuesday), the following articles are available:

- From light waves to quantum physics: the science behind smart washbasins [newsth.live/smartwashbasins](#)
- Long UPSC prep cycles take heavy toll on aspirants' mental health [newsth.live/upscprep](#)

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Timings CHENNAI			
TUESDAY, APR. 21			
RISE	05:54	SET	18:22
RISE	09:08	SET	22:38
WEDNESDAY, APR. 22			
RISE	05:53	SET	18:23
RISE	10:12	SET	23:40
THURSDAY, APR. 23			
RISE	05:53	SET	18:23
RISE	11:17	SET	00:00

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	38	26
Chennai Airport	37	28
Chennai City	34	28

Chennai Airport Today
37°C Morning will be comfortable. Day will be very warm and uneasy. Night will also be comfortable. Dry weather to prevail.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
37°C The weather will be dry. Day will be very warm. Night will be comfortable.

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THE HINDU
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Girl from South America treated for scoliosis in city

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

When Sedi Van Genderen, 15, from Suriname in South America, developed a spinal deformity, her mother, Iris, scoured the internet in search of an expert who could cure her. The treatment for Sedi's condition was not available in their country.

Apollo Hospitals, Chennai, was one of many healthcare centres she emailed, and she got a reply from them the same day. "The next day, I was on a video call with the doctor. He told me to come to Chennai as soon as possible for my daughter's treatment," Ms. Van Genderen said. That was in January. In February, the mother and daughter travelled to India. Sedi suffered from adolescent idiopathic scoliosis, an abnormal curvature of the spine, for which there is no identifiable cause.

Sanjay K. Hegde, direc-



In good health: Sanjay K. Hegde, director, spine surgery, Apollo Speciality Hospitals, and the team of doctors with the patient and her mother at the press meet held in Chennai on Monday. M. SRINATH

tor, spine surgery, Apollo Speciality Hospitals, Tey-nampet, speaking at a press meet on Monday, said in Sedi's case, the condition was making rapid, aggressive progress. Once Sedi arrived, she was found to have a severe degree of curvature. In the first phase of treatment, she was put on halo gravity traction for three weeks to improve spinal alignment, said Appaji Krishnan, senior consultant, spine surgery. This brought the curvature down a little.

Following this, a two-stage surgical intervention, led by Dr. Hegde, was performed. The procedures were done with intraoperative neuromonitoring. Following the surgeries, Sedi's spine was 75% corrected, Dr. Appaji said, noting that the entire process was a team effort. The teenager thanked her doctors and the entire hospital team and said she was looking forward to going back home, swimming, and hanging out with her friends.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Delimitation and women's reservation had no correlation, and the two issues were clubbed together [by the BJP-led Union government] with the intention of creating confusion and blaming the opposition, N. Ram, Director, The Hindu Group, said in Chennai on Monday.

Speaking on the topic 'Big Win for Tamil Nadu! Defeat for Union Government!! How and Why?' at a meeting organised by the Chennai Thinkers' Forum, he said the Bill had certain in-built contradictions that the government could not explain in the Lok Sabha or in subsequent meetings. "Women's reservation was used as a cover for delimitation, [as many people, including [Congress leader]



N. Ram, Director, The Hindu Group, speaking at a seminar on delimitation organised by the Chennai Thinkers' Forum on Monday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Rahul Gandhi, stated. That is true. Women's reservation and delimitation have no correlation whatsoever," Mr. Ram asserted. Brought in at a juncture when four major States – Tamil Nadu, Kerala, West Bengal, and Assam – were facing elections, the BJP-

led Centre attempted a "smoke-and-mirrors approach" to create confusion and break the INDIA bloc, he said quoting an editorial in *The Hindu*. While stating such a move would have little impact on Tamil Nadu or West Bengal, Mr. Ram

lauded Chief Minister M.K. Stalin for having been able to comprehend the designs of the Centre and project the pitfalls of the Bill in appropriate fora. The freeze on population-based delimitation, which was introduced in 1976 and then extended in 2001 during the Vajpayee regime, was a compromise that came riding on two principles: States that failed to control population growth will have greater weightage in Parliament and Assemblies, while the developed States will be punished for their success. The BJP, he charged, planned to carry out the delimitation exercise before the Census was conducted and even before the 2029 elections, so that it translated to more weightage for the party in the Hindi-speaking belt. "It

gathered momentum and people. Candidates including Rhevanth Charan (Maduravoyal), V.S. Babu (Kolathur), and G. Balamurugan (Ambattur) joined in, while streams of supporters on bikes and on foot merged into the procession. The turnout also slowed traffic on several stretches, including the Padi flyover

through Villivakkam, Anna Nagar, and Virugambakam, where he campaigned for Aadhav Arjuna, V.K. Ramkumar, and Sabarinathan respectively. On each stretch, Mr. Vijay was atop his vehicle, acknowledging supporters with gestures, and the crowd responded with undiminished enthusiasm. As the convoy moved, it

While the BJP leader took aim at the ruling party for lapses in governance, the TVK president did not address those who gathered to see him during the poll campaign, which began in Ponneri. Traffic on stretches, including Padi flyover and parts of Anna Nagar, where vehicles were forced to inch forward as crowds spilled onto the roads. Meanwhile, Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader K. Annamalai also led an extensive campaign across Chennai and its suburbs on Monday, canvassing votes for the BJP as well as its National Democratic Alliance (NDA) partners.

Extending support to alliance partners, he also campaigned for AIADMK candidates across key constituencies, including S.R. Vijayakumar (Villivakkam), Abhishek Rangasamy (Egmore), S. Gokula Indira (Anna Nagar), P. Benjamin (Maduravoyal), and K.P. Kandhan (Sholinganallur), among others.

Mr. Annamalai also addressed meetings for PMK candidate K.N. Sekar in Ambattur, AMMK's G. Senthamizhan in Saidapet, Indian Democratic Party's Venkatesan in Pallavaram, AIADMK's Saravanan in Alandur, and Chitlapakam Rajendiran in Tambaram.

Chennai: Gnanasekaran, who was convicted in the Anna University student sexual assault case, was admitted to the Government Stanley Hospital on Monday, after suffering a seizure in Puzhal prison, the police said. Prison sources said

Gnanasekaran, lodged in the convicts' block of the Central Prison, developed a seizure around 1.30 a.m. The staff provided first aid and shifted him to the hospital, where he was admitted to the emergency ward under police security.

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INBRIEF



Selvaperunthagai alleges ‘unlawful confinement’

TNCC president K. Selvaperunthagai on Monday alleged that “Hindi-speaking Income Tax” officials “unlawfully confined” him within the Sriperumbudur constituency on a day when Congress leader Rahul Gandhi was campaigning in Tamil Nadu. I-T officials reportedly conducted searches at his residence on Monday. In a statement, Mr. Selvaperunthagai alleged that the “deliberate action, carried out at a politically sensitive moment, is a clear and calculated attempt to obstruct democratic functioning and weaken the activities of the Opposition.” He further said: “The timing of this intervention exposes its true intent - not enforcement, but intimidation. It reflects a disturbing pattern of using Central agencies as instruments of political pressure to silence dissent, restrict political participation, and create an atmosphere of fear among Opposition leaders and workers.”

Madras High Court stays case against BJP leader Annamalai

The Madras High Court on Monday stayed all further proceedings in a criminal case pending against former BJP State president, K. Annamalai, before a judicial magistrate court in Salem, for reportedly claiming at a press meet that Pasumpon Muthuramalinga Thevar, in 1956, warned of performing ‘blood abhishekam’ for Madurai Meenakshi Amman “if atheists continued to insult theists”. Justice M. Nirmal Kumar granted the interim stay, dispensed with the personal appearance of Mr. Annamalai before the trial court, and ordered notice, returnable by June 15, to the complainant Piyush Manush, on the petitioner’s plea to quash the private complaint. According to the complainant, an activist based in Salem, Mr. Annamalai, while addressing a press meet in September 2023, had attributed certain statements to Muthuramalinga Thevar without any evidence, thereby attempting to disturb public order.

Kejriwal asks people of T.N. not to vote for NDA, says BJP has captured AIADMK

If you vote for the NDA, the BJP and the AIADMK will stop the good work carried out by the DMK government because their intention is to loot the people, says the former Chief Minister of Delhi

Aloysius Xavier Lopez
CHENNAI

The BJP has “captured” the AIADMK, and the AIADMK has committed the biggest crime against the people of Tamil Nadu by bringing the BJP to the State, Aam Aadmi Party leader and former Delhi Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal said here on Monday. Speaking at an election campaign meeting in the presence of Chief Minister M.K. Stalin in the Egmore (SC) constituency, he said, “The NDA is not the AIADMK and the BJP; the NDA is only the BJP. The AIADMK is in the grip of the BJP. See what has been done in Bihar. Nitish Kumar was Bihar’s Chief Minister till yesterday. Today, he has been reduced to a Rajya Sabha Member. Why? This will be done to the AIADMK too. The AIADMK will be broken into three parts, and the BJP will take over [the party]. The BJP wants to capture Tamil Nadu. But the people of Tamil Nadu hate the BJP. Tamil Nadu does not want the BJP. The AIADMK has committed the biggest crime against the people of Tamil Nadu by bringing the BJP to the State. So, think before you vote for them.” Mr. Kejriwal said, “One year ago, in Delhi, the people made a mistake; they voted for the BJP. Now, all the good work we have



Strong support: Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin and Aam Aadmi Party leader and former Delhi Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal campaigning at Pulianthope Junction in Chennai on Monday. R. RAGU

done in Delhi has been stopped by the BJP. The schools we started in Delhi have been stopped. The clinics that we started in Delhi have been stopped. The free medicines and treatment we offered have all been stopped. We made electricity free. Now, the people are getting electricity bills amounting to thousands of rupees. I came to Tamil Nadu and saw the good work done in Tamil Nadu. If, by mistake, you vote for the NDA, all the good work will be stopped, and you will regret it. I request you to vote for the DMK if you want the good work to continue in Tamil Nadu.” Pointing to the BJP go-

vernment’s decision to stop the welfare measures initiated for the people of Delhi, Mr. Kejriwal said, “If, by mistake, you vote for the NDA, the BJP and the AIADMK will stop the good work [of the DMK government] because their intention is to loot the people.” According to him, Mr. Stalin is doing a very good work. “I am told that almost 1.3 crore women head of family are getting ₹1,000 a month. No other State is giving it. You have the Chief Minister’s Breakfast Scheme at schools. No other State implements such a scheme. When the girls pass out of school, they get ₹1,000 a month

for higher education. No other State gives it,” he said. Mr. Stalin said that he invited the former Delhi Chief Minister to Tamil Nadu because he was one of the leaders who continued his struggle against the “fascist BJP”, even after being in prison in a case fabricated due to political vendetta. Praising the “good work” done by Mr. Kejriwal, the DMK leader said, “The BJP has prevented Mr. Kejriwal from forming the government for the third time through an electoral fraud. But he continues his struggle for the people, determined to defeat the BJP.”



Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu campaigning for NDA candidates in Coimbatore on Monday. S. SIVA SARAVANAN

DMK, Congress have betrayed women and the country: A.P. CM

The Hindu Bureau
COIMBATORE

Telugu Desam Party (TDP) leader and Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu, on Monday, alleged the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) and the Congress had betrayed the country and its women by not supporting the “33% reservation for women”. “It is a great injustice for the society, South India, and women. I am asking the DMK one straight question - Why did you oppose this Bill? What did you gain from it? You are saying Tamil Nadu has defeated Delhi. You did not defeat Delhi; you defeated the share of South India,” he said during an election campaign in Coimbatore. [The DMK and Congress had opposed the Constitution Amendment Bill linked to delimitation.] He said Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the Union government had clarified that there would be a 50% increase in Lok Sabha seats for all States. “I requested (Union Home Minister) Amit Shah long back that the proportion-

ate share of South India should be protected. They agreed and have done it.” Mr. Naidu said he had been fighting for higher reservation for women for the last three decades. “The DMK has demotivated women in the country. It is saying it has achieved something great. What have you [DMK] achieved? It is a defeat for women. It is a betrayal of women and the nation,” he said. If women’s reservation is implemented without delimitation, men will be affected, he added. Mr. Naidu claimed that wherever there is a “double engine sarkar”, there is development, and that Tamil Nadu had not seen any development in the last five years. It was once a very progressive State and the headquarters of South India, but Chennai is gradually losing its glory. Andhra Pradesh is promoting intra-linking of rivers. It is also supporting Tamil Nadu’s cause through the Telugu Ganga project. It will soon give water to the Cauvery too. Finally, the Ganga and Cauvery rivers will be linked, he further said.

Virudhunagar fireworks unit blast toll rises to 25; identity of 22 victims established, says Collector

The Hindu Bureau
VIRUDHUNAGAR/CHENNAI

The death toll in the blast that took place at Vanaja Fireworks Unit at Kattannarpatti here rose to 25, with two more workers succumbing to burns early on Monday. R. Petchiammal, 51, and V. Panchavarnam, 56, of Tiruthagal, who suffered over 80% burns in the explosion that occurred on Sunday, died at the Virudhunagar Government Medical College hospital (VGMCH) on Monday. Six others, including a 12-year-old boy, are undergoing treatment. A total of 20 persons, including seven police personnel and four Fire and Rescue Services personnel, who were injured in the second blast, are also undergoing treatment. The identity of 22 workers have been established. The post-mortem, which



A section of the public and relatives of the workers killed in the blast at Vanaja Fireworks Unit, outside the mortuary of Virudhunagar Government Medical College Hospital on Monday. G. MOORTHY

began late on Sunday, was carried out by forensic experts from the VGMCH, Government Rajaji hospital in Madurai, and Tirunelveli Medical College Hospital. With 18 of the deceased hailing from Servaikarapatti, hundreds of villagers and relatives of the victims gathered on the VGMCH premises since Monday morning. They said none of the district officials consoled them, despite the ac-

cident being the result of their negligence. The relatives demanded ₹30 lakh and a government job for a member of each of the bereaved family. Several lapses General secretary of Virudhunagar district Fireworks and Matches Workers’ Association M.C. Pandian said several lapses in safety measures were found at the Vanaja Fireworks Unit.

After prolonged talks, cheques worth ₹5 lakh from the State government were handed over to the families. The Department of Labour handed over ₹50,000 in cash to each of the families of the deceased, the Collector said. He said efforts would be taken to expedite the process to obtain ₹2 lakh compensation from the Prime Minister’s Relief Fund. Earlier, BJP State president Nainar Nagenthran and MP Durai Vaiko visited the VGMCH and offered their condolences to the families of the deceased. Mr. Nagenthran said the government must take steps to prevent such accidents and sought higher compensation. Meanwhile, the Vachakarapatti police booked the fireworks unit owner, Eswari, and her husband, Muthumanickam, under various sections of the BNS and the Explosives Act.

A mention was made by Advocate R. Karunanidhi before the Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court, urging the court to take suo motu cognisance of the blast. ‘Systemic failure’ Making the mention before a Division Bench of Justices N. Sathish Kumar and M. Jothiraman, he said the recurring disasters in Virudhunagar district demonstrate systemic failure. The judges sought response from the State and posted the pending matter for hearing to April 21. Environmental organisation Poovulagin Nanbargal has called for an immediate ban on fireworks manufacturing and the closure of all violating units. In a statement, the organisation said the blast was the result of continued regulatory failures and widespread safety violations in the industry.

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court on Monday dismissed a batch of nine writ petitions, filed by DMK Rajya Sabha member R. Girirajan, seeking a direction to the Directorate of Enforcement (ED) to register money laundering cases against AIADMK leaders S.P. Velumani, C. Vijayabaskar, M.R. Vijayabaskar, P. Thangamani, R. Kamaraj, K.P. Anbalagan, K.C. Veeramani and two others on the basis of corruption cases pending against them. First Division Bench of Chief Justice Sushrut Arvind Dharmadhikari and Justice G. Arul Murugan dismissed the petitions after ED Special Public Prosecutor (SPP) N. Ramesh questioned their maintainability as well as the locus standi of the MP to file such petitions when he was neither a complainant nor a witness in any of those

corruption cases being probed by the Directorate of Vigilance and Anti Corruption (DVAC). The SPP said the Supreme Court in Madhavan Pillai versus Rajendra Unnithan (2025) had held that a High Court could not pass a “drastic order” of directing the ED to register an Enforcement Case Information Report (ECIR), under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act of 2002, just because it comes to a prima facie conclusion that a predicate offence existed against the individuals concerned. He said a writ of mandamus could be issued by the courts only if the petitioner had given a representation to the authorities concerned and such representation had not been considered by them. However, in the present case, the writ petitioner had not given any representation to the ED before filing the present batch of nine writ

petitions seeking issuance of a writ of mandamus against the Central agency, he said. The SPP also said it was a politically motivated litigation in which the ED had been “unnecessarily dragged in”. He said the petitioner belonged to the DMK and had filed the cases against the AIADMK leaders during the Assembly elections 2026, though the corruption cases against those leaders had been pending with the DVAC for several years. He further said the ED prefers to refrain from disclosing, in open court, any kind of proceedings it had taken or intends to take against the nine individuals, since it would affect the investigation. He, however, said, the newspapers had already reported about the ED having initiated proceedings against Dr. C. Vijayabaskar. “Therefore, all these nine writ petitions are not bonafide,” he said.

DMK failed in its attempts to break AIADMK and PMK, alleges EPS

The Hindu Bureau
SALEM

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami on Monday accused the DMK of trying to break the AIADMK and the PMK and said that the DMK did not succeed in its attempts. Campaigning in his Edappadi constituency, along with PMK president Anbumani Ramadoss, Mr. Palaniswami said, “While I became the Chief Minister in 2017, I faced many problems. Dr. Anbumani also faced the same problems.

The DMK tried to break the AIADMK and the PMK, but the DMK was not successful in its attempts.” This election will put an end to the DMK regime. As money comes easily through ganja, and DMK cadres are allegedly involved in ganja sales, it could not be eradicated. But, after the AIADMK comes to power, the ganja menace will be eradicated in three months. There is no law and order in the DMK regime and there is no safety for children or women. Now, Chief Minis-

ter M.K. Stalin has asked youths to stay away from drugs. He has, therefore, acknowledged that youths in the State have become addicted to drugs. Thanking the people of Edappadi, who, he said, were the reason for his becoming the Chief Minister and the AIADMK general secretary, Mr. Palaniswami turned emotional and broke down. “Only in the AIADMK can an ordinary person become the Chief Minister,” he added. The schemes brought by the AIADMK were put on

hold by the DMK. After the AIADMK comes to power, these schemes would be implemented, he said. When DMK leaders R.S. Bharathi and Tiruchi N. Siva criticised former Chief Minister K. Kamaraj, Mr. Stalin did not condemn them, he added. Rising prices Stating that prices of essential commodities skyrocketed during the DMK regime, Mr. Palaniswami said that the DMK government did not take steps to control the price. Due to a hike

in construction materials prices, the poor and middle-class could not realise their dream of building a house. The AIADMK has made 297 promises for this election. “People may approach me at any time. Is it possible to meet Mr. Stalin? During the AIADMK regime, 16,626 people got old age pension for the first time. Through 7.5% internal reservation for government school students, 3,000 students got medical seats. “During the COVID-19 pandemic, I visited 32 dis-

tricts,” Mr. Palaniswami added. “The prime accused in the Anna University student sexual assault case, Gnanasekaran, got sick and was admitted to the hospital. If anything happens to his life, the DMK government is responsible for that. They know that the AIADMK will come to power, and if he were to be investigated, the truth will come out. There is information that something happened to him in the prison,” Mr. Palaniswami alleged.



Joint fight: AIADMK leader Edappadi K. Palaniswami and PMK president Anbumani Ramadoss campaigning in Edappadi constituency in Salem on Monday. E. LAKSHMI NARAYANAN

P.V. Anvar, former MLA and Kerala State convener of the All India Trinamool Congress, has said that a State committee meeting of the party held in Kochi on Monday passed a resolution to sever all ties with the party's national leadership and reposition itself as "a secular, democratic, and socialist political outfit aligned with the politics of the Congress and the United Democratic Front." He added that a new party will be formed by May 15.

ED launched the probe based on FIRs filed by Karnataka Police alleging crypto scam; it searches premises linked to MLA N.A. Haris and Aqeeb Khan, grandson of ex-Union Minister Rahman Khan

The searches were conducted under the provisions of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act, 2002 (PMLA) in connection with a cybercrime and cryptocurrency-related money laundering case in-



On duty: CRPF personnel stand guard during the ED search at the residence of N.A. Haris in Bengaluru on Monday. J. ALLEN EGENUSE

volving Srikrishna Ramesh, alias Sriki, and others. The agency has alleged that both individuals are close associates of Sriki and among the key benefi-

ciaries of the proceeds of the crime.

Searches were also carried out at locations associated with Aqeeb Khan, grandson of former Union

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

A special court of sessions for criminal cases against former and present MPs and MLAs, in Karnataka, has made scathing observations against three police officers for openly admitting that they had tendered “false evidence” under oath before the magistrate in the murder case involving Congress MLA Vinay Kulkarni.

The court called it a “cavalier” act that erodes pu-

blic trust in the justice system. "Such an act of tendering false evidence cannot be tolerated," the court observed.

The special court on April 15 convicted Kulkarni and 16 others for murdering BJP leader Yogeshgouda Goudar in 2016.

The court called for punitive action to prevent future blunders that would damage the public's faith in judicial proceedings while ordering registration of a perjury case against the three police officers.

The Hindu Bureau
PEDDAPALLI

In a gruesome incident, a three-year-old girl was mauled to death by a pack of stray dogs at Katnapalli village in Sultanabad mandal of Telangana's Peddapalli district on Monday.

The deceased was identified as Divya Behra, the daughter of a migrant labourer couple from Odisha.

According to sources, the girl was playing in front of their rented room when

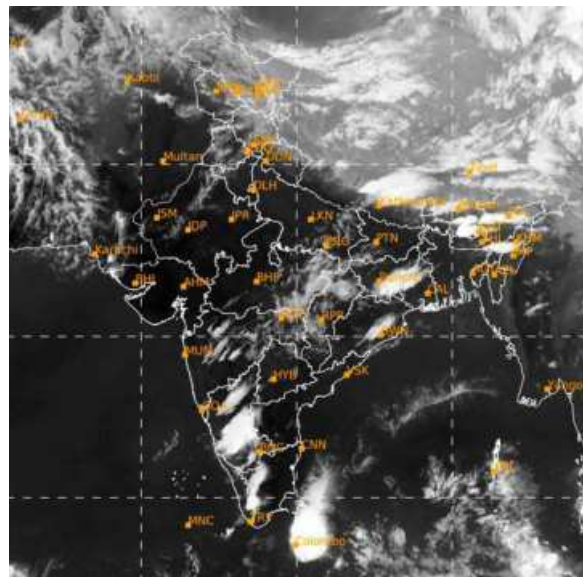
the stray dogs attacked her and dragged her away to a nearby agricultural field.

By the time local people noticed and reached the spot, the child had sustained severe injuries and died.

The child's parents were engaged in work at the time of the incident.

The shocking incident brought the spotlight back on the unabated menace of stray dogs in several villages in Sultanabad mandal and the living conditions of migrant workers.

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 18.15 HRS)

Forecast for Tuesday: Heavy/very heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Arunachal Pradesh, Assam and Meghalaya. Thunder storm with lightning/gusty winds likely at isolated places over Manipur, Mizoram, Tripura, Sikkim, West Bengal, Odisha, Telangana Andhra Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Maharashtra, Karnataka and Kerala

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala	—	35.6	27.0	Kozhikode	—	36.4	28.8
Ahmedabad	—	40.2	24.9	Kurnool	—	42.7	27.4
Aizawl	—	32.7	19.9	Lucknow	—	41.6	24.4
Allahabad	—	44.4	24.6	Madurai	—	40.2	26.3
Bangaluru	—	35.8	24.4	Mangaluru	—	33.7	27.6
Bhopal	—	39.9	28.5	Mumbai	—	34.9	26.1
Bhubaneswar	—	35.7	25.5	Mysuru	—	36.4	20.3
Chandigarh	—	38.1	18.6	New Delhi	—	39.5	22.4
Chennai	—	37.6	27.9	Patna	—	40.0	26.6
Coimbatore	—	38.0	25.2	Port Blair	—	33.0	25.5
Dehradun	—	37.0	20.2	Puducherry	—	34.7	27.7
Gangtok	1	22.3	14.4	Pune	0.4	40.8	25.5
Goa	—	35.6	27.0	Raipur	—	44.0	30.3
Guwahati	117	31.6	21.0	Ranchi	—	40.1	26.3
Hubbali	—	37.9	22.2	Shimoga	—	37.0	26.2
Hyderabad	2	39.9	26.0	Srinagar	—	25.6	6.4
Imphal	—	30.0	20.3	Thiruvananthapuram	0.2	23.5	9.4
Jaipur	—	40.0	27.0	Thiruvananthapuram	—	35.5	27.7
Kochi	10	33.0	22.2	Tiruchi	—	39.1	26.6
Kohima	—	24.0	17.0	Vijayawada	—	39.0	27.7
Kolkata	—	36.4	27.0	Visakhapatnam	—	33.0	27.7

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO	CO	PM2.5	PM10	CODE	
Ahmedabad	.88	.47	.12	.92	.159		In observation at 4.00 p.m., Mandi
Bengaluru	.22	.28	.17	.54	.108		Gobindgarh, Punjab
Chennai	.66	.13	.28	.20	.49		recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 350 indicating an unhealthy level of pollution in contrast, Puducherry recorded a healthy AQI score of 29
Hydrabad	.31	.76	.38	.174	.293		
Kolkata	.74	.23	.61	.61	.76		
Lucknow	.7	.42	.32	.61	.68		
Mumbai	.12	.53	.63	.248	.133		
Pune	.4	.18	.45	.64	.149		
Vishakhapatnam	.26	.64	.38	.41	.94		
Vasaphapatnam	.51	.58	.22	.22	.38		

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM2.5 & PM10: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease



Chief Electoral Officer, Tamil Nadu

GE to TNLA, 2026



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MGNREGA Job Card



Bank / Post Office Passbook (with photograph)



Health Insurance Smart Card (Ministry of Labour / Ayushman Bharat)



Pension Document (with photograph)



PAN Card



Smart Card issued by RGI under NPR



Indian Passport



Service Identity Card (Govt./PSU/Public Limited Companies)



Official Identity Cards issued to MPs/MLAs/MLCs



Driving License



Unique disability ID (UDID) card, issued by M/o social justice & Empowerment, Govt. of India



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23 April 2026



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A plan of change

The BJP achieved its aim of leading Bihar after a long waiting game

Samrat Choudhary was sworn in as the 24th Chief Minister of Bihar, on April 15, 2026, becoming the first-ever politician from the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) to hold the office. His elevation follows a pattern that the BJP has mastered for its growth – outgrowing regional partners and inverting the hierarchy in its favour. The ground realities in the State had shifted in the 2020 Bihar election when the BJP won 74 seats, overtaking the Janata Dal (United), which unexpectedly slid to 43 of the 243 seats in the Assembly. In the 2025 Assembly elections, the BJP won 89 seats while the JD(U) won 85. The BJP waited a little longer before easing out JD(U) supremo Nitish Kumar, who was elected to the Rajya Sabha after two decades as Chief Minister. Mr. Choudhary’s elevation follows yet another pattern of the BJP’s flexibility in handing over the top post to recent entrants into the party. He was in the Rashtriya Janata Dal and the JD(U) before joining the BJP in 2017. Mr. Choudhary belongs to the Koeri Kushwaha caste and has been the OBC face of the BJP. The BJP-JD(U) alliance, along with other smaller parties, has dominated Bihar politics by mobilising the upper castes, the non-Yadav OBCs and the Extremely Backward Classes (EBC). While the upper castes have limited options other than the National Democratic Alliance, the EBCs can be volatile in their party preferences.

The BJP waited six years even after overtaking the JD(U) in numerical strength, precisely out of fear of unsettling the EBC voters who trusted Mr. Kumar. Mr. Choudhary’s appointment as Chief Minister is the BJP’s direct bid to reach into the OBC-EBC base that it used to negotiate through Mr. Kumar. This transition could potentially open up new social alignments within the BJP and the JD(U). The fate of the JD(U) itself, now that Mr. Kumar is no longer at the helm, is uncertain. Mr. Choudhary has become Chief Minister on the strength of the BJP central leadership’s confidence in him, but the task of winning the confidence of party workers and voters rests entirely on his shoulders. Bihar also carries a considerable governance deficit that needs urgent attention. The State has a dynamic and young population, yet its education and health sectors remain in distress. Mr. Choudhary will have to show vision and commitment to build on the marginal gains that the State has made in recent years and focus on human development, in the absence of which any amount of infrastructure investment will be suboptimal. Bihar’s progress would have a multiplier effect on the entire country and its new Chief Minister must consolidate quickly and marshal all available forces towards that end.

The price of negligence

Human involvement in hazardous industries must be minimal

In yet another gruesome explosion at a fireworks unit on April 19 in Tamil Nadu’s southern Virudhunagar district, 25 workers were killed and eight others injured. The number of injured went up to 20, including policemen and firefighters, after another explosion occurred at the unit later. In the past four years, at least 134 people have died and 89 have been injured in such explosions in the district, which is known for its concentration of fireworks units. It is an outright misnomer to describe this type of explosion as an accident, as any preliminary investigation would reveal. Accidents are associated with elements of surprise and unanticipated occurrence. But in the case of Virudhunagar, it is known to every worker – even if no separate sensitisation course is conducted – that the firecracker industry is hazardous and that any negligence of safety norms can result in disaster. Moreover, such explosions have occurred at regular intervals in the district, claiming the lives of scores of workers, most of whom come from economically weaker sections of society. Beyond expressing condolences and announcing solatium, the authorities at the Union and State levels have done little of substance to reduce, if not eliminate, the risk of such explosions. What they should and could have done is intensify meaningful monitoring, the absence of which is now and then felt in the form of explosions.

The Virudhunagar incident has brought into focus the role of law enforcement authorities in ensuring proper supervision, as the unit in question was operating on a Sunday – observed as a holiday by the fireworks industry – apparently without permission. Contrary to the norms specified in the licence issued by the district authorities, which allow only a dozen people to work in any fireworks unit at any given time, 40 people were present at the unit at the time of the explosion on Sunday. These two aspects, judging by the frequency of such explosions, are not unique to this particular fireworks unit. Official inspections may have taken place but they would have been carried out more as a ritual than as a meaningful exercise. There have, of course, been reports of a manpower shortage within the monitoring authorities. While coming down heavily on wrongdoers, including unlicensed units and those working regularly in violation of safety norms, the officials should also ensure that, in the name of tighter supervision, legitimately functioning units are not subjected to harassment. They should also not gloss over the economic reality of the district where the industry provides employment to lakhs of people in a region that is largely arid and dependent on rain-fed irrigation. Sober elements in the industry should consider ways to increase the use of automation and reduce human involvement.

The strategic vulnerability in India’s LPG supply model

India’s Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG) problem is not a passing shortage. It comes from a gap that has grown too wide to ignore. India consumed about 33.15 million tonnes of LPG last year, but domestic production met only about 40% of that need. The remaining 60% had to be imported. Put plainly, India’s total LPG demand is now about 250% of indigenous production, while annual LPG imports are equal to about 150% of domestic LPG output. That is not a minor balancing gap. It is a significant mismatch between what India produces and what its kitchens consume.

This matters because LPG in India is overwhelmingly a household fuel; commercial LPG accounts for less than 10% of national consumption. So, the imported molecule is not mainly feeding a flexible industrial user that can cut runs or switch feedstock. It is going into domestic kitchens. This is what makes India’s LPG dependence more serious than a normal product-import issue. A petrochemical plant can slow down. A household kitchen cannot.

No longer a dependable corridor
The crisis now has exposed this sharply. About



Shrikant Madhav Vaidya
Former Chairman of Indian Oil Corporation Ltd. and an energy strategist

India’s LPG use is mainly household-based, heightening import vulnerability

90% of India’s LPG imports normally transit the Strait of Hormuz. India must now accept that the Strait of Hormuz cannot be treated as a routinely dependable corridor for household fuel security. Even if the present tensions ease, the old assumption of uninterrupted normality will not return easily. The risk attached to this route has now entered the strategic calculation in a lasting way.

Import dependence alone, however, does not tell the full story. Japan imports a larger share of LPG than India does. China and South Korea also import large volumes of LPG. But what matters is not only how much a country imports. It is where the molecule goes, what alternatives households already have, and how much storage supports the system.

Lessons from Japan
The *table* shows why raw percentages can mislead. Japan appears more import-dependent than India on LPG. Yet, Japanese household vulnerability is far lower – LPG serves only about 40% of households. Electricity accounts for about 55% of residential final energy use, and city gas also has a large residential base. More importantly, Japan has about 108.3 days of LPG stock through national and private reserves. Japan imports more, but it cushions that dependence with alternatives and storage.

China and South Korea are different again. In China, a large share of its LPG demand is driven by the petrochemical sector. In South Korea, household energy is supported much more by natural gas and electricity.

India’s position is more exposed because the imported molecule goes overwhelmingly into domestic kitchens. India’s problem is not that it imports LPG – many countries do. India’s problem is that it imports LPG for the one use that is hardest to defer and also the hardest to replace quickly.

India’s storage position also needs to be seen clearly. The Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell reports about 15 days of LPG tankage cover in the broad operational sense across import locations, bottling plants, refineries and fractionators. But visible underground cavern-based deep storage is only about 140,000 tonnes – 60 TMT at Visakhapatnam (Andhra Pradesh) and 80 TMT at Mangaluru (Karnataka) which is equal to only about 1.5 days of national demand. The first number shows that the system is not empty. The second shows that reserve-style protection is still very thin for a country of India’s size and import dependence.

There is another point that deserves attention. India is not buying LPG in a loose, neutral global market. The exportable pool is not large, and it is already heavily claimed by a few Asian buyers. Just four Asian countries absorb a little over

half of the world’s exportable LPG pool. And the rest is not sitting idle waiting to be redirected. Much of it is already tied up in petrochemicals, household cooking and heating, and autogas. This is why any sustained loss of dependable Gulf supply can quickly tighten the market.

What India should do
How can India reduce its vulnerability?
First, it should stop treating all LPG molecules as one pool. During the present disruption, India has already directed refiners to prioritise propane and butane for cooking LPG rather than for petrochemical or gasoline-blending use. That logic should continue. Domestically produced LPG and refinery-origin C3/C4 (propane/butane) streams should be reserved first for household fuel security. Petrochemical users should increasingly arrange their own feedstock imports. The government should not have to defend domestic kitchens and industrial feedstock demand from the same protected pool.

Second, India should build a deeper LPG buffer. An initial goal of two to three weeks of protected cover for the household pool would be a sensible start. At current demand levels, that means about 1.3 million tonnes for 14 days and 1.9 million tonnes for 21 days. This is a large jump from the current cavern capacity, but it is the minimum scale at which India can begin to claim meaningful resilience.

Third, India needs a sustained campaign for electric cooking in urban and semi-urban India. This cannot be a one-season appeal. It has to continue over the years. Households with reliable power, adequate wiring and access to induction cooking should be encouraged to shift their primary cooking load away from LPG. A ‘Give it up 2.0’ plan should be launched.

The aim is simple: reduce the number of homes for which the LPG cylinder remains the first and only kitchen fuel. Piped Natural Gas (PNG) should expand where density supports it, but electricity is the broader lever.

India’s LPG vulnerability will continue to persist unless policy addresses a basic mismatch: demand that is too high relative to domestic production; imports that are too concentrated in a single corridor; and excessive dependence concentrated in household kitchens. The answer is not simply to buy more LPG cargoes. It is to reserve domestic molecules for kitchens, separate petrochemical demand, build more storage, and steadily reduce the number of homes that rely on LPG alone.

India’s LPG problem is not a passing shortage. It is an enduring mismatch between what the country produces and what its kitchens consume. This is why India’s asymmetric LPG demand will remain a lasting vulnerability – unless the design of the system itself changes.

Why India is more exposed

High household dependence and tight global supply make the LPG risk sharper

A household LPG vulnerability matrix					
Country	LPG import share of total demand	Total LPG demand as % of domestic production	LPG imports as % of domestic production	Household kitchen criticality of LPG	LPG cover / storage position
India	60%	250%	150%	Very high	15 days operational tankage cover (PPAC); ~1.5 days in cavern-based deep storage
Japan	70%	333.3%	233.3%	Low	108.3 days
China	40.4%	167.7%	67.7%	Low to moderate	No clear public LPG-days figure verified here
South Korea*	~74.5%	~391.7%	~291.7%	Low	15-30 day stockholding obligation framework

* Indicative, based on publicly available market data

Who absorbs the global exportable LPG pool?

Country	LPG imports used for comparison	Share of global LPG exports*	Main use of LPG
China	36.7 MMT	26.3%	Mainly petrochemical-driven at the margin
India	19.89 MMT	14.2%	Mainly household cooking fuel
Japan	9.8 MMT	7%	Mixed: household/commercial + chemicals
South Korea*	~7 MMT	~5%	Mixed, with strong industrial/petrochemical role
Total	73.39 MMT	52.5%	-

* Using global LPG exports of 139.8 MMT. South Korea is indicative

The price of a war far above the ground

Recently, at New Delhi’s Indira Gandhi International Airport, a departure board quietly transitioned from “On Time” to “Delayed,” and then to “Rescheduled.” The official explanation – rerouting due to airspace restrictions over West Asia – barely concealed the deeper reality of the Iran war steadily redrawing the economic and operational contours of global aviation. What appears as episodic inconvenience is, in truth, an outward manifestation of a structural disturbance whose implications extend far beyond delayed departures.

Airspace closures across critical corridors have forced airlines into circuitous routes, often extending flight durations by two to eight hours depending on the routes, inflating fuel consumption and compressing already slender operating margins. Simultaneously, jet fuel prices surged to nearly \$195-\$197 a barrel. Given that fuel constitutes between 25% and 40% of total airline operating costs, such increases could destabilise the industry in which net margins rarely exceed 3% to 5%.

The impact is already visible: ticket prices have increased by 10%-20% in several markets, fuel surcharges risen by over 30% in certain cases, and thousands of flights cancelled globally, especially along the Europe-Asia axis. Yet, to dwell excessively on these symptoms is to risk overlooking a deeper question, which is what trajectory this disruption is likely to assume in the near future.

The new normal

The risk of sustained tensions between the United States-Israel and Iran is likely to persist over the medium term. A probable outcome is the gradual normalisation of inefficiency. Rerouted flight paths, once conceived as temporary adjustments, may become embedded within airline operating models, permanently altering route economics. In such a scenario, the industry would witness a sustained elevation in cost structures driven by higher fuel burn, increased crew costs, extended turnaround times, and reduced aircraft utilisation.

Over time, this would lead to rationalisation of airline networks, with marginal long-haul routes, particularly those linking secondary cities,



Sanchita Chatterjee
Associated with Consumer Unity and Trust Society (CUTS) International



Sohom Banerjee
Associated with CUTS International

The Iran war and geopolitics will reshape global aviation economics

becoming economically untenable. The geography of global aviation itself may undergo a subtle, yet significant, reconfiguration. An outcome of this may be traditional West Asian hubs ceding some of their pre-eminence to alternative transit points in Türkiye, Southeast Asia, or even India. For Indian carriers, however, the implications are more acute. Their structural dependence on West Asian air corridors for connectivity to Europe and North America renders them particularly vulnerable, creating a persistent imbalance between rising costs and the constraints of a price-sensitive market.

A more disquieting possibility lies in the prospect of escalation within or after the ceasefire period. Such a scenario may lead to wider airspace closures and sharper energy market disruptions; the consequences could assume a systemic character. Fuel prices, already volatile, may become both elevated and unpredictable, further amplifying operational uncertainty. Flight networks could contract, particularly across high-density intercontinental corridors, while elevated fares and geopolitical anxiety dampen demand. Unlike the COVID-19 pandemic, where demand collapsed due to health concerns, this would constitute a cost-induced contraction, wherein airlines continue to operate but under severe financial strain.

Handling the disruption

For India, such a scenario would be especially onerous. Aviation turbine fuel (ATF), already burdened by high taxation, would reflect the full force of global price shocks, compounded by currency depreciation. The sector could find itself confronting a confluence of pressures, escalating input costs, weakening demand, and constrained pricing power, potentially precipitating consolidation or strategic retrenchment among carriers with limited financial resilience.

Yet, crises, even of this magnitude, are not without possibilities of bearing latent opportunities.

A third trajectory – less immediate but strategically consequential – lies in adaptive reconfiguration. Faced with sustained geopolitical

uncertainty, airlines and policymakers make a strategic decision to recalibrate. This could appear in the form of a diversification of routing strategies, reduced dependence on any single geopolitical corridor, alongside investments in ultra-long-haul aircraft capable of bypassing traditional transit hubs altogether. The emergence of alternative aviation hubs outside conflict-prone regions could gradually redistribute traffic flows, while policy interventions, particularly in markets such as India, may address structural inefficiencies, including the rationalisation of ATF taxation and the renegotiation of bilateral air service agreements. In such a scenario, India’s current vulnerability could, with strategic foresight, be transformed into opportunity, positioning the country as an alternative node in the evolving architecture of global aviation.

This is a challenge

Amidst these future possibilities, one conclusion asserts itself with increasing clarity: geopolitics should no longer be treated as an exogenous shock to the aviation sector; rather, it should be seen as an intrinsic variable shaping its economics and operations. The long-standing assumption of predictable skies, upon which the industry’s finely optimised networks were constructed, has probably been irreversibly unsettled.

Airlines must now internalise uncertainty, embedding scenario planning, dynamic pricing and strategic flexibility into the core of their operations. Possibly, for airlines, this is the equivalent of a ‘Covid-shock’ of global supply chains and an opportunity to re-strategise and recalibrate. For India’s aviation sector, already navigating the complexities of high input costs and price-sensitive demand, the challenge is particularly formidable.

What is unfolding is not merely a transient disruption, but the gradual emergence of a new aviation order, one defined not by the efficiency of open skies, but by the exigencies of a fractured and uncertain geopolitical landscape. The question is no longer whether turbulence will persist, but whether the industry possesses the strategic agility to navigate it.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Cracker factory blast

It is saddening that fire disasters continue unabated in Tamil Nadu’s Virudhunagar district (Front page, April 20). The gruesome incident is a clear testament to the gross

negligence of officials and agencies in discharging their mandated responsibilities. Standard operating procedures appear to be observed more in breach than in compliance. The time has

come to mechanise various processes involved in the manufacture of fireworks, rather than relying heavily on manual labour. Meanwhile, an in-depth scientific study could be undertaken to rework the

composition of the chemicals used in this hazardous industry.
V. Johan Dhanakumar,
Chennai

The time has come for us to stop celebrating our

festivals with crackers. I have never understood the “enjoyment” people derive from the ear-piercing sounds of exploding crackers. Unless we change the way we celebrate, the firecracker industry will

continue to flourish, and poor workers will remain vulnerable.

Sukumaran C.V.,
Kongad, Palakkad, Kerala

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

‘BJP used women as a shield to push delimitation’

Government wanted to divide the INDIA bloc and deploy their usual tactics to push through the Constitution Amendment Bill but they had not anticipated the unity in the alliance which is why they appear rattled, the Congress leader says; the next Kerala CM will be chosen in a democratic fashion, says Venugopal, who played the role of a troubleshooter during the Assembly election campaign

INTERVIEW

K.C. Venugopal

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

As the Narendra Modi-led government launched an all-out attack on the Opposition as anti-women, Congress general secretary K.C. Venugopal, in an interview to *The Hindu*, defended the Opposition and accused the Centre of trying to divide the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) to push through delimitation under the Constitution Amendment Bill. Edited excerpts:

The government knew that it didn't have the numbers, yet it pushed for a Constitution

Amendment Bill to link the women's reservation law with the delimitation process. Why do you think the government did this?

The Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill was introduced in Parliament hastily when two large States were in the middle of election campaigning. The BJP hoped that creating a sense of urgency would cause chaos and disruption within the Opposition ranks. Their intention was to divide the INDIA bloc and deploy their usual tactics to push through such a Bill.

Soon, it became clear that it was an attempt to put in place a mechanism to gerrymander constituencies, along the lines of what they did in Assam and Jammu and Kashmir. The objective was to redraw India's political map

in their favour, and women's reservation was used to hide their intentions. This should also be seen as a failure of a regime that labels every decision a 'masterstroke' and each manoeuvre a 'Chanakya' move. In reality, they fumbled in their attempt to push through an unconstitutional Bill and are now trying to set a narrative to cover this up.

Contrary to their expectations, the Opposition was alert and united. They had not anticipated such unity in the INDIA bloc, which is why they appear rattled.

How will you counter the BJP's campaign that the Congress is anti-women and that is why it did not allow a Bill in their favour?

It is a campaign that is unlikely to be accepted by the people. The Congress has



SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

consistently championed women's empowerment, including reservations for women, and cannot be accused of opposing women's reservation. The women's reservation Bill had already been passed in 2023, which we supported. We have been at the forefront of women's empowerment – whether by implementing reservations in local bodies or by giving the country its first woman Prime Minister, the first woman Speaker, and the first woman President. The

All India Congress Committee has also been led by women on multiple occasions, unlike the BJP or the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh [RSS], which has yet to see a woman at the helm.

In this instance, by using women as a shield, the BJP attempted to push through delimitation, which failed. That is why it is now pushing a campaign against the Opposition. The people of India can spot such campaigns. The fact that BJP MPs had placards ready

immediately after the Parliament session ended suggests a coordinated attempt at narrative setting.

In Kerala, you led an aggressive campaign against the Left Front government for the Assembly poll but in Delhi, you coordinated with the Left to team up and fight against the government. How are you managing such contradictions?

At the national level, the INDIA bloc has stood united against what it sees as undemocratic policies of the NDA. The BJP's approach is described as "divide and rule", whereas the INDIA bloc seeks to bring people together, rising above differences to protect democracy and the Constitution. The alliance is a broader national coalition, even though there are

differences at the State level. These differences were discussed, and a consensus was built from the initial meetings. There is clarity among the parties and there is no contradiction. This was also the case during the UPA [United Progressive Alliance] era, when parties retained independent positions in States but were united at the national level.

In the run-up to the Kerala Assembly polls, you were seen as a troubleshooter bringing factions together. If the UDF wins, are you a contender for Chief Minister?

Kerala has witnessed a strong campaign by the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF). The LDF [Left Democratic Front] will be rejected by the people, and the UDF

will form the next government. There is no need for any leadership discussion at this stage. When the time comes to decide on the Chief Minister, the party will take a decision in a democratic manner.

What is your response to the PM's address to the nation, attacking the Congress?

The Prime Minister's address appeared overtly political, with repeated references to the Congress during an election period. Using an official platform in this manner raises concerns about adherence to the Model Code of Conduct. It is also concerning that the Election Commission is sleeping at the wheel and appears to be a puppet of the government. As far as the PM's speech is concerned, it was political messaging after defeat.

From Page One

Iran undecided on talks; U.S. to keep blockade

"The deal that we are making with Iran will be far better than the JCPOA," he wrote in another post, referring to the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action. "If a deal happens under Trump, it will guarantee peace, security, and safety, not only for Israel and the Middle East, but for Europe, America, and everywhere else."

Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian said the U.S. was seeking the country's surrender and that Iran would never submit to force. "Deep historical mistrust in Iran toward U.S. gov conduct remains, while unconstructive and contradictory signals from American officials carry a bitter message; they seek Iran's surrender. Iranians do not submit to force," the President said in a statement.

Last week, Iran said it would reopen the Strait of Hormuz for commercial vessels, after Mr. Trump announced a 10-day ceasefire in Lebanon. Mr. Trump "thanked" Iran for the move, but added that a U.S. blockade of Iranian ports would stay in place until both sides reach a deal. Iran then took a U-turn from its previous announcement and reasserted its control over the critical waterway. On Saturday, the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps fired at two tankers, preventing them from crossing the Strait of Hormuz, following which Mr. Trump renewed his threat of hitting Iran's civilian infrastructure.

"The U.S. Navy attacked the Iranian container ship *Touska* on Sunday night while it was sailing from China to Iran, subsequently taking control of the vessel," Tasnim reported.

9.8 lakh deletions in Odisha's voter rolls after electoral mapping process

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

The names of as many as 9.8 lakh voters have been deleted from the electoral rolls in Odisha since the commencement of the elector mapping process ahead of the special intensive revision (SIR).

"Approximately 9.8 lakh deletions have been carried out by the Electoral Registration Officers since the commencement of the elector mapping process. However, a substantial number of complaints have been received regarding wrongful deletion of names, including cases where electors were found to be present and instances where booth-level officers had neither conducted field visits nor carried out proper verification prior to deletion," the Office of the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) wrote to the Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) on April 18.

According to the Office



According to the Office of the CEO, around two lakh Form-7 applications received after April 2, 2026 have been kept on hold. PTI

of the CEO, around two lakh Form-7 applications received after April 2 have been kept on hold. Form-7 is filed for objecting to the inclusion of another person or one's own name on the electoral roll on specific grounds, including death, duplication, or shifting of residence.

The EROs have been instructed to carry out door-to-door survey, and physically verify the authenticity of voter rolls, which impacts final deletion.

"In case of death cases, names of deceased electors should be deleted only after due verification... Prior to deletion, notice must be served at the last known address of the elector," the letter from the Office of the CEO said.

The EROs have also been asked that all Demographic Similar Entries cases must be thoroughly verified. "In cases of suspected duplicates or doubtful matches, notices should be issued to the

concerned electors and due process must be followed before taking any action," the letter said.

The EROs and Additional EROs or their authorised representatives should physically verify at least 50% of Form-7 applications received after April 2 by personally contacting the applicants. Moreover, notices must be served to the elector at the last known address, and all statutory procedures must be followed, the letter said.

In cases where deletion has already been carried out wrongfully, the elector should be re-enrolled immediately with due diligence and care, the Office of the CEO added.

"Upon completion of the verification process, the ERO will furnish a written certificate confirming that at least 50% of the cases have been physically verified and that all prescribed procedures have been duly followed prior to deletion," the letter said.

SC to seek a report on the functioning of tribunals for SIR

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday expressed initial reluctance to entertain a plea quoting media reports that the Election Commission (EC) has infused nearly seven lakh new voters through the Form 6 route into the West Bengal electoral roll long after it has been frozen, saying it did not want to embark on a "fishing inquiry".

The reaction from a Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant was in response to an oral mentioning made by senior advocate Menaka Guruswamy.

In a separate oral mentioning, senior advocate Devadatt Kamat submitted that the 19 appellate tribunals, constituted to hear appeals against both exclusions and inclusions from the State electoral roll following the special inten-

There are 19 appellate tribunals constituted to hear appeals on the West Bengal electoral roll

sive revision (SIR) exercise, have not been "functioning" as yet. He also mentioned that only online applications were allowed.

The tribunals, composed of retired High Court Chief Justices and judges, were ordered to be constituted by the top court on March 10.

The court had declared that electors purged from the voter list but cleared by Appellate Tribunals by April 21 or 27 should be allowed to vote in the Assembly election.

On Monday, the court said it would get a report from the Calcutta High Court Chief Justice about the functioning of the tribunals.

21 killed as bus rolls down hillside in J&K

Union Minister Jitendra Singh, who represents the Udhampur constituency in the Lok Sabha, confirmed the death toll. "Twenty-one casualties so far and 61 injured. Injured have been shifted to Udhampur Hospital, while one more seriously injured is being airlifted to Government Medical college Jammu... All possible assistance is being provided," he said in a post on X.

Local people and teams from multiple security agencies worked together to transport the injured to the hospital. The Army said its units deployed in the area rescued dozens of civilians after the accident. "It plunged nearly 70 feet into a gorge. The impact led to multiple casualties, with several passengers trapped inside the mangled vehicle," the Army said in a statement.

It said that troops from a battalion of Gorkha Rifles, who were *en route* to Samnabanj for training, "were the first to reach the site". "They immediately launched rescue operations, evacuating trapped passengers from the wreckage under challenging terrain conditions," the Army said.

An ad-hoc incident control centre was swiftly established at the site under the Commanding Officer of a battalion of DOGRA Regiment to coordinate rescue and relief efforts. "A total of 10 teams, comprising personnel from DOGRA Regiment and Gorkha Rifles, were mobilised for the operation," it said.

President Droupadi Murmu and Prime Minister Narendra Modi condoled the loss of lives in the accident. "An *ex gratia* of ₹2 lakh from PMNRF would be given to the next of kin of each deceased, while the injured would be given ₹50,000," the Prime Minister's Office said in a statement. Chief Minister Omar Abdullah said the government would ensure a thorough investigation into the incident. He announced an *ex gratia* of ₹2 lakh to the next of kin of each deceased, ₹1 lakh to those seriously injured, and ₹25,000 to persons who sustained minor injuries.

Congress seeks probe into fresh killings in Manipur

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Monday demanded an immediate, time-bound probe into the latest killings in Manipur, including those of two children, and called for urgent peace measures, compensation for victims, and institutional reforms to restore normalcy in the violence-hit State.

Addressing a press conference, Inner Manipur MP A. Bimol Akojiam alleged that both the Centre and the State government had "abdicated responsibility" of protecting lives and ensuring peace. The party has submitted a memorandum to Prime Minister Narendra Modi seeking immediate intervention.

Referring to the April 7 incident at Tronglaobi village in Bishnupur district where two children were killed and their mother injured, Mr. Akojiam termed it a "gruesome reminder" of continuing insecurity.

He also cited a separate firing incident at a Central

The party has submitted a memorandum to the Prime Minister seeking intervention

Reserve Police Force (CRPF) post in Gelmon village that left three persons dead and several injured.

'Restore normalcy'
"The violence on April 7 is a reminder that the situation is not under control. It would be a dishonest pretension if one thinks that violence has come down in Manipur," Mr. Akojiam said, adding that the Manipur Pradesh Congress Committee had submitted a fresh memorandum to the Governor.

Calling for accountability, the party demanded a time-bound investigation into the Tronglaobi killings and strict action against armed groups and individuals involved in violence. It urged the government to restore normalcy in affected districts.

A day before inauguration by PM Modi, fire breaks out at Rajasthan refinery

Saptaparno Ghosh
BALTORA

A fire broke out in a refinery-cum-petrochemical complex in Rajasthan's Balthora district on Monday afternoon, a day before Prime Minister Narendra Modi was to inaugurate it.

Confirming the incident, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG) said that the fire took place in the vicinity of the crude distillation unit of the HPCL Rajasthan Refinery Limited (HRRL) refinery. Consequently, the inauguration has been postponed.

No casualties

"Due to an unfortunate fire incident today in the vicinity of the crude distillation unit at the HRRL refinery, the scheduled dedication of the refinery by the Honourable Prime Minister on April 21 has been postponed," the Ministry said on social media. "A revised date for the dedication will be announced in due



Thick smoke rises from the HPCL Pachpadra Refinery in Balthora district, Rajasthan, on Monday. PTI

course," it added. The Ministry confirmed that there have been no reports of any casualties, and an investigation has been ordered to ascertain the cause and suggest remedial measures. It stated that the fire has been bought under control.

The HPCL Rajasthan Refinery Limited (HRRL) refinery, located in the Balthora district of Rajasthan, is a greenfield refinery-cum-petrochemical complex with an overall capacity of 9 million metric tonnes per annum (MMTPA) with 2.4 MMTPA accounting for its

petrochemical production capacity.

HRRL is a ₹79,459 crore joint venture between HPCL and the Government of Rajasthan, with the latter holding an equity stake of 26%.

Bhajanlal Sharma, Chief Minister of Rajasthan, in a social media post, described the situation as "unfortunate". Separately, he added in his post, "The grand inauguration of this refinery, which is a symbol of hope for the people of the State, would soon be done by the Honourable Prime Minister himself."

Activists allege MCC violation in PM's address

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

More than 700 civil society activists, former bureaucrats and academics have written to the Election Commission alleging violation of Model Code of Conduct (MCC) by Prime Minister Narendra Modi in the national address he delivered on women's reservation on April 18.

In a letter addressed to the Chief Election Commissioner dated April 20, the activists demanded an inquiry into Mr. Modi's address, claiming that it was a "clear and blatant" violation of the MCC. The use of official government machinery by the Prime Minister, "for what amounted to electioneering" during the operation of the MCC, constituted its "serious breach", it said.

The letter was signed by Congress leader Digvijaya Singh, former bureaucrats Najeed Jung and M.G. Devashayam, musician T.M. Krishna, and activists Anjali Bhardwaj and Yogendra Yadav, among others.

‘Diaspora backs BNP in Bengal, keen to invest’

The BJP on Monday claimed that the Bengali diaspora was in favour of a regime change in West Bengal and willing to invest in the State. Addressing a press conference in Kolkata, BJP State president Samik Bhattacharya alleged that the ruling Trinamool Congress “failed” to create an investment-friendly environment, leading to an “exodus of companies from the State”.

He said Bengalis working in countries such as the U.S., the U.K., Australia, and Singapore lent support to the saffron party, asserting that a “change in West Bengal has become imperative”.

The BJP is the only investment-friendly party, Mr. Bhattacharya said. Members of the Overseas Friends of BJP also joined the press conference of the party leader virtually. PTI



Samik Bhattacharya says the BJP will make West Bengal more investment-friendly.

23% Bengal poll candidates face criminal cases

Around 23% of the candidates in the fray for the West Bengal Assembly polls, have declared criminal cases against themselves, according to the Association for Democratic Reforms. The poll watchdog analysed affidavits of 2,920 candidates and found that a total of 683 candidates had declared criminal cases.

Out of the 1,475 candidates in Phase 1, 345 (23%) have declared criminal cases, while 294 (20%) have declared serious criminal cases. In Phase 2, out of 1,445 candidates analysed, 338 (23%) have declared criminal cases, while 295 (20%) have declared serious criminal cases. Of the candidates analysed, 208 of 293 from the BJP, 112 of 290 from the Trinamool Congress, 94 of 198 from the CPI(M), and 70 of 293 from the Congress have declared criminal cases.



To fight atrocities against women, we will create a ‘Durga Squad’, and anyone who troubles women will be given strict punishment

RAJNATH SINGH
Defence Minister

T.N. polls: EC makes seizures worth ₹1,200 cr.

Tamil Nadu Chief Electoral Officer Archana Patnaik on Monday said that surveillance teams have so far seized cash, gold and silver articles, gift materials, liquor and drugs, worth over ₹1,200 crore across the State. As on April 20, a total of ₹169.85 crore in cash was seized from various places in the State. PTI



Women’s quota Bill was passed in 2023. But Modi slept over it for 30 months only to wake up before the West Bengal and Tamil Nadu polls

MALLIKARJUN KHARGE
Congress president



Rahul Gandhi addressing a poll campaign meeting at Sawyerpuram in Thoothukudi on Monday. N. RAJESH

RSS is trying to rule T.N. by proxy, says Rahul Gandhi

The Hindu Bureau
NAGERCOIL/ THOOTHUKUDI/ TIRUNELVELI

Congress leader and Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Monday alleged that the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) is attempting to rule Tamil Nadu “by proxy”.

Addressing a rally in Mandaikadu in support of the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam-led Secular Progressive Alliance (SPA) candidates contesting across the six constituencies of Kanniyakumari district, he said: “The RSS is planning to, and trying to, rule Tamil Nadu by proxy. The same way Donald Trump [President of the United States] controls the Prime Minister of India, the Prime Minister of India wants to control Tamil Nadu through the AIADMK.”

On the other hand, the DMK, Congress, and their allies “are defending Tamil language, culture, and history from the RSS”, he said, adding the RSS “hates the Dravidian idea” because they know that Tamils can challenge them. Tamil Nadu has shown a progressive vision to the rest of the country, with the politics in the State historically rooted in social justice, he said. “We want Tamil Nadu to be run by the people of Tamil Nadu; the men and women of Tamil Nadu should decide its future,” he said.

Mr. Gandhi further alleged that the BJP seeks to weaken the diversity of States. Referring to Manipur, he said wherever possible, the BJP attempts to capture power and govern a State from the national capital. Mr. Gandhi also alleged that the BJP does not have the courage to communicate this directly to the people of Tamil Nadu, but has instead taken control of the AIADMK, a “glorious political party” that has contributed to the development of the State.

Mr. Gandhi said the AIADMK once had leaders who truly represented the people of Tamil Nadu, but has now become an instrument for the BJP to enter Tamil Nadu. He alleged the leaders of the AIADMK has surrendered themselves to the BJP due to their corruption.

Personal connection

In the Srivaikuntam constituency in Thoothukkudi district, he highlighted his personal connection with Tamil Nadu. Mr. Gandhi said that this bond with the people of the State goes beyond politics and has continued across generations in his family. He assured that he would protect the interests of Tamil people, protect the Tamil language and ensure that Tamils have full representation in the country. Drawing comparisons with Bihar politics, Mr. Gandhi alleged the BJP aimed to establish a government in Tamil Nadu that would function under its control, and wants a Chief Minister who would act according to its direction. “No matter what dream they have, they will never ever control the people of Tamil Nadu,” he said.

Campaigning at Nanguneri in Tirunelveli district, he said if the BJP really wanted the women’s reservation Bill to be passed, it should table in Parliament the Bill presented in 2023 for which the entire Opposition will extend its support. He accused the the BJP of attempting to change the electoral map of the country in the guise of passing the Bill. “They were trying to change the number of seats each State gets. They were trying to reduce the representation of South India, northeast India, and of smaller states. They were attacking the idea of the Union of States. And that is why we defeated that Bill in Parliament. We will defeat it again and again,” he said.

IN FOCUS

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

With reports of clashes in key Assembly constituencies in West Bengal surfacing on Monday, there is concern over the free and fair conduct of the election in the State.

A clash erupted at a rally of the Indian Secular Front (ISF) in Bhangar when Trinamool Congress supporters staged protests and tried to block it. The rally was led by ISF candidate Nawshad Siddique, MLA. Trinamool supporters, who had gathered in large numbers, raised “Joy Bangla” slogan, directed at the rally.

ISF supporters retaliated by shouting “thief, thief” slogan, at the Trinamool workers. The police had to resort to a baton charge to bring the situation under control. Bhangar has been a hotbed of political violence with regular clashes between Trinamool and ISF supporters.

A similar clash between Trinamool and Bharatiya Janata Party workers was reported in Nandigram as



High alert: A total of 2,400 companies of Central forces have been deployed in West Bengal, more than double the number deployed during the 2021 election. ANI

both parties complained of attacks by each other. As tensions prevailed, Central forces reached the spot to bring the situation under control.

A crude bomb was recovered from outside the house of a BJP worker in the Natabari area of Cooch Behar district.

In a related development, a Trinamool worker was injured after he was shot at by unidentified miscreants in the Gosaba area

of Sundarbans on Sunday night.

With only two days left for polling in the first phase of the high-stakes election on April 23, Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee came down heavily on the alleged “selective” targeting of Trinamool workers.

A pre-emptive list of miscreants, reportedly made by the Election Commission and circulating on informal social media groups, was heavily criticised by Ms. Banerjee.

“We will fight these issues at every inch. The list that is circulating, I got hold of it from a source... They are only targeting the TMC, as if TMC workers are only thieves and the BJP people are all innocent,” the Chief Minister said at a public rally on Monday.

Trinamool MP and senior advocate Kalyan Banerjee has moved the Calcutta High Court, in anticipation of the arrest of

over 800 Trinamool workers before the election. He has raised an apprehension that as part of preventive arrests, many party workers may be held without cause.

Mr. Banerjee has asked the Chief Justice of the High Court to take immediate action on the issue. The court has agreed to hear the matter, and is likely to take it up on an urgent basis.

As a pre-emptive measure, the West Bengal Police arrested 135 criminals on Sunday night. Since the announcement of the polls, the EC took down at least 11,000 misleading social media posts, “with West Bengal Cyber Crime Wing taking down 7,936 posts”, a police statement said on Sunday.

Police (ITBP) whose personnel have been deployed across the State ahead of the election.

“Our mission in West Bengal transcends routine security; it is about safeguarding the sanctity of the ballot,” Praveer Ranjan, Director-general, CISF, said.

In all, 2,400 companies of Central forces have been deployed in the State, which is more than double the number deployed during the 2021 election.

Complaint filed

However, this drew criticism from the Trinamool leadership as Mahua Moitra, MP, accused the BJP and Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar of planning a military-style takeover of the State.

The Trinamool filed an official complaint with the EC against the “arbitrary” deployment of the Central forces without providing valid reasons to recognised political parties for the deployment.

“The complete absence of disclosure gives rise to grave apprehensions of selective targeting and misuse of discretion,” the complaint filed by the Trinamool on Monday read.

Both switched role from actor to politician, but comparing MGR and Vijay is a facile act

Ramya Kannan
CHENNAI

Odious as comparisons are, it is impossible to avoid them during election season. Parties and leaders, their manifestos, agendas, welfare schemes, ideologies, sartorial elegance, or lack of it too, are often analysed at great length in attempts to understand the political lay of the land in the present through the lens of the past. This election, in Tamil Nadu in 2026, one comparison that could scarcely be ignored is the well-worn likening between Vijay, the actor-turned politician, and M.G. Ramachandran, the State’s former Chief Minister.

However, this is a facile comparison. All comparisons stop at the single original fact that both were actors who took the political route, jumping into elections when the chance came up. K. Hariharan, author, film-maker and academic, explains why this is so: “Elections are not a first day, first show phenomenon. It is important that people planning to jump into the electoral fray test the waters first. As MGR did – he spent a long time in politics before he launched the AIADMK.”

MGR spent years in politics and the DMK before deciding to launch his party. His entry into politics was carefully crafted, a



In the spotlight: Vijay during an election campaign rally for TVK candidates in Chennai’s Anna Nagar on Monday. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

song in every film in Dravidian propaganda mode, and his formulaic films elevating him as the hero of the downtrodden. It was in 1967, three elections after its debut, that the DMK established a government in the State. Among the factors that facilitated this was of course the anti-Hindi agitation in the State, Congress leader K. Kamaraj’s decision to step down to attend to party affairs, and the sympathy wave that resulted out of MGR being shot at by actor M.R. Radha.

After differences rose between MGR and M. Karunanidhi, who had taken over the DMK leadership, the former broke off and formed his party – the AIADMK – in 1972, creating the political Dravidian duality in the State that was to continue a long while.

The AIADMK’s debut election in 1977 turned out to be a spectacular success, one of the best political debuts in the State and country. In its very first State-level contest, it defeated the incumbent DMK and entrenched itself into the Dravidian landscape. It is this success that has spurred some commentators to fallaciously connect with Mr. Vijay’s entry into politics.

“Apart from the fact that they are both popular actors in Tamil cinema, further comparisons between MGR and Mr. Vijay turn sour,” Mr. Hariharan says. While MGR used a formulaic cinematic model to build the image of a leader of the masses, Mr. Vijay’s cinematic career was devoid of this kind of construct. He was a lone player, hardly attending political events or media

interviews, developing his popularity, in a sense, through a closely guarded, nearly sequestered personal life. “Mr. Vijay had no boots on the ground, until he formed the TVK, the political party. Without a rich experience of working with the people, he still has posited himself as the alternative to parties that have had decades of grassroots experience.”

But if we need to make comparisons, then one between Mr. Vijay and Telugu Desam Party founder and former Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N.T. Rama Rao might actually have more points of intersection, Mr. Hariharan says.

Andhra pride issue

“NTR had expressed his wish to come into politics many a times to film journalists who used to travel with him, but frankly nobody took him seriously,” explains Dasu Kesava Rao, former head, *The Hindu’s* Andhra Pradesh bureau.

One story goes that NTR wanted a seat in the Legislative Council, but the then Chief Minister, Anjappa, did not warm to the idea. It is said that NTR’s political ambitions were ignited when he was invited to the swearing-in of Bhavanam Venkatrami Reddy as Chief Minister. He launched the TDP in March 1982, and within nine months, he

won the election and was established as the Chief Minister of Andhra Pradesh, riding in on the failure of the Congress and the Janata Party in the State. He invoked the Andhra pride issue, riding the Telugu regionalism factor right through.

Another cinema-star turned politician from Andhra Pradesh, Chiranjeevi, also launched his party a year before the first election he contested in. The Praja Rajyam Party (PRP) was founded by the Telugu film actor on August 26, 2008, with the avowed aim of providing a people-centric alternative to the existing political establishment.

A mammoth crowd gathered at the launch of the party in Tirupati. Does that sound familiar? If you are looking for more similarities, at a political rally of the PRP in Dharmavaram, a stampede occurred, killing two persons, and injuring several, while for Mr. Vijay the fell swoop came at a political rally in Karur.

The path in front of Mr. Vijay is then the poetic two roads that diverged in a yellow wood. The decision to start on the journey alone is his; which road he takes may not depend on him directly, though as a consequence of his actions, the one he is propelled down on.

EC will ensure free, fair and transparent election in Bengal: CEC

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

With two days to go for the first phase of the Assembly election in West Bengal, Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar on Monday said elections in the State would be held in a “free and transparent” manner.

“In these elections of West Bengal, ECI (Election Commission of India) will leave no stone unturned to hold free, fair and transparent elections,” Mr. Kumar said in a statement.

The election would be “fear free, violence free, intimidation free, inducement free, *chappa* (voter reaches the booth to find his vote already cast) free, booth-jamming free, source-jamming free”, he added.

The EC would ensure that no employee of the State government, local bodies, or autonomous bodies influenced the electoral process, Mr. Kumar said. “Each and every elector of West Bengal should exercise his/her vote in a fearless manner,” he added.

The Assembly elections in West Bengal will be held in two phases, on April 23 and 29. Counting will be held on May 4.

The Railways has said that it will operate 908 special trains during the summer to address the anticipated rise in passenger demand from April 15 to July 15 due to vacations, festivals, and peak travel months. These trains will operate 18,262 trips to cater to the increased travel demand. Out of these, 660 trains have already been notified, accounting for 11,294 trips, ensuring that a substantial portion of the planned services is already available for passenger booking and travel planning well in advance. The Central Railway with 3,082 trips has emerged as the top zone with maximum summer special train trips.

A District and Sessions Court in central Assam on Monday convicted 20 people in connection with the mob lynching of two Guwahati-based youth in Karbi Anglong district almost eight years ago. The court acquitted 25 other accused for lack of sufficient evidence. Abhijit Nath and Nilotpal Das died after 150-200 villagers assaulted them while they were returning from Kangthilangshu falls, which they visited as part of their environmental study. According to prosecution, Nath and Das were attacked on suspicion of being child lifters, a rumour circulating on social media at the time. Despite identifying themselves and pleading for their lives, they were assaulted in public view.

Congress leader Pawan Khera approached the Gauhati High Court on Monday, seeking anticipatory bail in connection with a criminal case registered against him by the Assam police's Crime Branch in Guwahati. The case is based on an FIR lodged by Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma's wife, Rinihi Bhuyani Sarma, after Mr. Khera claimed that she possessed passports of three countries, owned luxury properties in Dubai, and had significant investments in Wyoming, the United States. The court listed the Congress leader's plea for hearing on Tuesday. Mr. Khera made the claims at press conferences in New Delhi and Guwahati on April 5.

Twenty-six candidates have bagged a perfect 100 NTA score in the engineering entrance exam JEE-Main, the National Testing Agency (NTA) announced on Monday. Over 13 lakh candidates appeared in the first edition of the exam in January and more than 10 lakh candidates in the second edition in April. Over eight lakh common candidates appeared in both sessions. Among the candidates who secured an NTA score of 100, five each are from Andhra Pradesh and Telangana followed by four from Rajasthan, three from Delhi, two each from Maharashtra and Haryana, and one candidate each from Chandigarh, Bihar, Tamil Nadu, Odisha and Gujarat. All are males. PTI

But the government pleader submitted that the offence against her is serious and alleged that Ms. Khan had actively participated in the crime. He said the offence is sensitive and related to atrocities against a woman and sought time from the court to file the government's reply.

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8	6	3	9	4	5	1	2	7
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2	1	9	6	7	4	3	8	5
9	7	2	4	1	6	8	5	3
1	8	4	5	9	3	6	7	2
6	3	5	7	8	2	9	1	4

Devotees ask if one should seek a guru or acharya. A guru is one who dispels agnana while an acharya is one who shows the disciple the right path. Adi Sankara was both guru and acharya, and therefore unparalleled.

INBRIEF



Hyundai, TVS partner for commercialisation of E3W

Hyundai Motor Company and TVS Motor Company on Monday said they have signed a joint development agreement to advance the development and commercialisation of electric three-wheeler solutions designed specifically to address India's last-mile mobility needs. The partnership has been formalised after the successful presentation of the E3W concept at the Bharat Mobility Global Expo 2025, the two companies said in a joint statement. PTI

Apple pauses data in antitrust case, CCI sets final hearing

Apple has not submitted data sought by India's antitrust body after an investigation found the U.S. firm abused its dominant position in the iPhone apps market, prompting the watchdog to fast-track a decision on penalties to a final hearing next month, an order shows. The Competition Commission of India (CCI) said in an April 8 order that Apple has not submitted details of its financials and its views on the investigation since October 2024. REUTERS

Officials seize suspected counterfeit Mounjaro pens

Indian drug regulators seized more than 260 suspected counterfeit pens of Eli Lilly's obesity and diabetes drug Mounjaro and said the main accused had ordered raw materials from vendors on Chinese e-commerce platform Alibaba. Officials on Saturday recovered the suspected fake pens from a vehicle on the outskirts of New Delhi and arrested two people accused of making and selling the drugs, the Haryana Food and Drug Control Administration said in a statement.

Core sector activity contracts 0.4% in March on war impact

Government data show that four out of the eight core sectors of the economy contracted in March 2026; growth in the full year of 2025-26 was the lowest since the COVID-19 pandemic

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

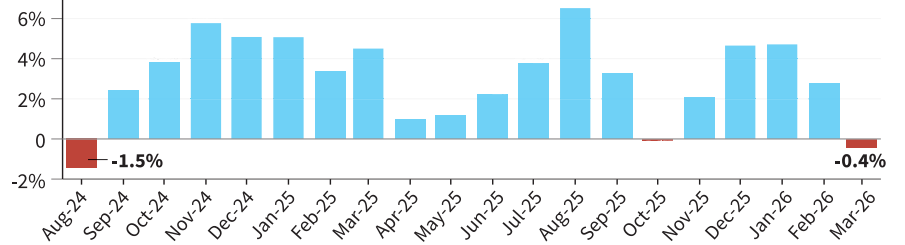
Activity in India's eight core industrial sectors contracted by 0.4% in March 2026, the first month after the war in West Asia broke out, according to data released by the government. This was the poorest performance for the sectors in 19-months.

The data on the Index of Eight Core Industries released by the Ministry of Commerce and Industry on Monday also showed that growth in the index stood at 2.6% for the full year 2025-26, the lowest since the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020-21.

In March 2026, the data showed that four out of the eight sectors measured in the index contracted over their levels in March last year. "While an adverse base weighed on electricity generation, a shortage of inputs amidst the West Asia crisis curtailed the fer-

Core contraction

The Index of Eight Core Industries contracted in March 2026 on the impact of the West Asia crisis



Source: Ministry of Commerce and Industry

tiliser output, which plunged by an unprecedented 24.6% year-on-year in the month," Aditi Nayar, Chief Economist at ratings agency ICRA said.

The fertiliser sector ended the year 2025-26 with a contraction of 0.1% as compared with a growth of 2.9% in 2024-25, which itself was the lowest since 2021-22.

The electricity sector contracted 0.5% in March 2026 on a relatively high base of 7.5% growth in March 2025. Over the course of 2025-26, the sec-

tor grew 0.9%, down from 5.2% in 2024-25.

"Besides, the growth in steel and cement output also weakened in March 2026 relative to February 2026, suggesting that construction activity slowed in the month," Ms. Nayar added.

Steel growth slumps

The steel sector saw growth slump to an 18-month low of 2.2% in March 2026, while the cement sector slowed to a 17-month low of 4%.

The only sector to see

relatively robust growth in March 2026 was the natural gas sector, which grew 6.4% as the government pushed oil marketing companies to increase their output in reaction to the constraints brought on by the West Asia crisis.

The crude oil sector, on the other hand, contracted by 5.7% in March 2026, the seventh consecutive month of contraction.

The coal sector contracted by 4% in March 2026, while the refinery products sector grew by 0.1% that month.

SEBI amends alternative investment fund rules

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

SEBI has sharply reduced the minimum investment required from individual investor in social impact funds to ₹1,000 from ₹2 lakh, to widen retail participation on the Social Stock Exchange (SSE).

This would align the minimum application size requirement for subscribing to Zero Coupon Zero Principal Instruments under SEBI's Issue of Capital and Disclosure Requirements Regulations, 2018 with the minimum investment value requirement for individual investors in Social Im-

pact Fund.

Earlier, AIF rules required individual investors to invest a minimum of ₹2 lakh in a social impact fund that invests in securities of NPOs listed or registered on the SSE.

Now, in its notification dated April 16, SEBI reduced this threshold to

₹1,000. To give effect to this, it amended the Alternative Investment Fund (AIF) rules. Additionally, SEBI said AIFs, which do not retain any funds after the expiry of their fund life, may be permitted to seek an "inoperative" status, subject to compliance with prescribed norms.

FY26 pharma exports up 2% even as March saw dip

N. Ravi Kumar
HYDERABAD

India's pharmaceutical exports rose more than 2% year-on-year to \$31.11 billion in FY26 despite a 23% slide in March amid the fal-lout of the West Asia war.

A new record, the exports bettered the \$30.47 billion registered in 2024-25. March incidentally had played a crucial role in shaping the overall FY25 performance as shipments to the all-important U.S. market surged in the face



U.S. tariffs played an important role in pharma export impact.

of an impending higher tariff regime.

In March 2026, pharma exports declined as much

as 23.17% to \$2,828.60 million (\$3,681.66 million), official numbers showed. The downturn was largely concentrated in the final quarter, driven by logistics disruptions and tariff-related uncertainties, a highly placed source said.

U.S. market pressure

Exports to the U.S., in particular, came under significant pressure, as the war disrupted shipping. U.S. tariff worries remained in 2025-26 too and there were concerns over potential ta-

riffs on branded patented drugs manufactured outside the U.S. Generic medicines retain a cushion, for now, an official said.

The impact of the evolving situation was not completely unexpected. Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal had told a meeting here earlier this month while "we are likely to land up better than last year," but the \$32 billion target set for FY26 is unlikely to be achieved. The performance in rupee terms may still be better given the the

currency depreciation."

Pharmaceuticals Export Promotion Council of India chairman Namit Joshi, who earlier estimated the March exports to be lower at anywhere between \$250 million to \$500 million due to the war impact, had said FY26 exports will be "somewhere near to last year achievement".

Up to February, the exports were nearly \$28.29 billion. "We have already achieved 5.6% growth up to February," Pharmexcil DG Raja Bhanu had said.

'Upgrading India-Korea trade pact for balanced partnership'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The decision by India and South Korea to upgrade Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) is aimed at moving towards a more balanced economic partnership and one not defined by huge trade deficits, Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal said.

Earlier, PM Narendra Modi and South Korean

President Lee Jae Myung announced the signing of many MoUs and the pact to upgrade the CEPA.

Addressing India-Korea Business Forum, Mr. Goyal said, "The fact we have a rapidly rising middle class with significant increase in their incomes, all of these make for a very good destination for Korean investment, Korean manufacturing," Mr. Goyal said.

"Our bilateral trade is

about \$27 billion," he said.

"We have been tasked by our two leaders that we should double this by 2030. So, we're looking at about 18% growth if we have to double it in the next four years," he added.

During his speech at the Business Forum, Mr. Lee said the bilateral trade between the two countries was not "large enough considering the size of India's economy."

There is a need to prioritise biofuel for aviation: IATA

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

Indian aviation's clean fuel transition must hinge on treating mobility as one integrated system and allocating limited feedstock more efficiently by prioritising biofuels such as ethanol for air transport as automobiles have more viable alternatives like electrification available, as per International Air Transport Association (IATA).

Under Sustainable Aviation Fuel (SAF) roadmap, India set phased blending targets of 1% by 2027, 2% by 2028 and 5% by 2030 for international flights, aligning with the goal of the International Civil Aviation Organization (ICAO) for achieving net-zero carbon emission from international aviation by 2050.

"India is well placed to meet short-term demand (for SAF) but for long-term needs there is a need for diversification and rationalisation of feedstock allocation for different sectors to avoid all ethanol being used by road transport,"



Preeti Jain

Preeti Jain, IATA head, net zero research & programme, told *The Hindu* in an interview from Geneva. Without prioritisation, the risk is aviation firms invest heavily in SAF capacity only to face ethanol shortages.

Biggest opportunity

A government commissioned report presented before ICAO General Assembly last year titled "Feasibility Study on SAF" identified SAF output via alcohol-to-jet (AtJ) process as the biggest opportunity for India.

The report cautioned competing demand for eth-

anol from road transport must be carefully managed as automobiles had many alternative fuel options, whereas aviation did not. But availability of input in the form of feedstock was not a constraint.

"We did a global feedstock assessment study which showed India was a hotspot and 10% of global bio feed stock was available in India. But I don't think even 2% or 3% of it is being now used," Dr Jain said.

As per IATA's Global Feedstock Assessment for SAF Production Outlook to 2050, India, U.S., Brazil and Europe were likely to dominate SAF biomass feedstock for SAF with 105 million tonne (mt) available by 2030 and 154 mt by 2050 out of a total requirement of 500 mt.

The aviation industry's key concern is the high cost of SAF, which could push up airfares, as it is now three to five times more expensive than conventional jet fuel. Dr. Jain said the issue can be addressed by subsidies for production and adoption by airlines.

GIFT City finance hub grants first family office permit

Reuters
MUMBAI

India's Gujarat International Finance Tec-City (GIFT City) has issued its first license to establish a family investment fund, marking a significant step in managing private wealth within the financial hub.

Permit was granted to Poornam Asset Management IFSC Pvt. Ltd., according to a GIFT City financial regulatory authority official who was not authorised to speak to the media.

The move underscores GIFT City's aim to build a globally-competitive and flexible regulatory ecosystem for foreign family offices and private wealth structures, the GIFT City financial regulatory authority said.

Some wealthy Asians are seeking alternatives to Dubai due to geopolitical tensions in the Gulf. Poornam Asset Man-

It underscores GIFT City's aim to build a globally-competitive ecosystem for foreign family office

agement has an authorised capital of ₹7 million (\$75,175.86) and is directed by Vineet Kulbandhu Sharma, currently based in London, public disclosures showed. Mr. Sharma is a fund manager of two funds based in Hong Kong and London.

Flight of capital issue

Previously, GIFT City provided in-principle approval to family offices linked to Indian billionaire Azim Premji and Infosys co-founder Narayana Murthy's family fund, Catamaran Artha. However, a final licence to the entities allowing them to manage wealth from GIFT City has yet to be granted due to concerns over potential flight of Indian capital, the official added.



Smooth transition: E85 is a fuel blend made of up to 85% ethanol and 15% petrol (gasoline) REUTERS

Draft rules for roll-out of Ethanol 85 fuel to be notified soon

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

The government will "very soon" issue draft rules on the roll-out of Ethanol 85 (E85) as vulnerabilities in oil exports exposed during the West Asia crisis sharpen the focus on alternative fuels, a senior government official said. While a final date is yet to be decided, the official said the roll-out is expected "in a couple of years".

E85 is a fuel blend made of up to 85% ethanol and 15% petrol (gasoline).

"Draft regulations will be notified very soon. There is consensus within the government. There is also market consensus and preliminary testing too has been carried out," the official said, speaking on condition of anonymity.

The E85 blend will be introduced as a separate fuel grade, distinct from E20, in which ethanol blending could go up to 27%, which is permissible under a notification issued in 2023, the official explained.

High levels of ethanol

blending offer several benefits, including "greater energy security for the country and a reduction in vehicular pollution," the official said.

Such a high-ethanol fuel will require dedicated engine compatibility, as well as separate dispensing infrastructure at fuel pumps that will also dispense E20 petrol.

An engine designed to run on E85 can also operate on lower ethanol blends, including E60 and E50.

On competing demands for ethanol-blended fuel, including from aviation, where India has a 1% blending target in aviation turbine fuel for international flights under the International Civil Aviation Organization's plan to achieve net-zero carbon emissions by 2050, the official said there was "surplus" ethanol available in the country.

The government has mandated the sale of petrol with up to 20% ethanol across all States and Union Territories from April 1.

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NOTICE INVITING BID
NIB No. 09/2025-26 Date: 23-03-2026
1. Sealed Single Stage Two-parts (Technical and Financial) unconditional bids are invited through E-bidding procedure by Secretary Rajasthan Medicare Relief Society (M.G.H.) Jodhpur up to 05:00 PM of 04.05.2026. Tender are to be submitted duly digitally signed in electronic format only on website http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in tender documents can be downloaded from above mentioned website. Details for the same are as follows:-
S. No. Name of the subject matter/ Specifications Estimated Cost (Lacs) Price of Bidding Document (Rs.) Bid Processing Fee (Lacs) Bid Security Fee (Lacs) Date and Time for download and submission of bids
1 Rate contract for Orthopaedic Implants & Accessories As mentioned in the Bid Document. 2700.00 5000/- 2500/- 54.00 As mentioned in the Bid Document
NIB Code SMC2526A0332 UBN No. SMC2526GLRC00445
Secretary
Rajasthan Medicare Relief Society (M.G.H.) JODHPUR
DIPRC/7/048/2026

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FOREIGN MEDICAL GRADUATE EXAMINATION (FMGE) – JUNE 2026
NOTICE
National Board of Examinations in Medical Sciences (NBEMS) shall conduct the FMGE – JUNE 2026 on 28-06-2026.
Applications are being invited from 21-04-2026 (03:00PM Onwards) to 11-05-2026 (Till 11:55 PM) at NBEMS website:
https://natboard.edu.in/viewnbexam?exam=fmge
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CM
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LEAKING RUNS

The last four overs were a horror story: GT batting coach Hayden



VIJAY SONEJI

As Gujarat Titans slumped to a heavy defeat against Mumbai Indians, batting coach Matthew Hayden lashed out at the death bowling. “When you look back at those last four overs, that was a horror story. Giving away 73 runs is unacceptable,” he said, adding that it was “a horrible day” for the bowlers barring Kagiso Rabada.

TEAM EFFORT

I studied the batters and talked to the captain, says Ashwani



VIJAY SONEJI

MI pacer Ashwani Kumar marked his first game of IPL 2026 with a four-wicket haul at the Narendra Modi Stadium. Under challenging conditions, he studied each batter carefully before executing his plans. “I studied batter to batter. The pitch was demanding. I talked to the captain, and we decided to act accordingly,” Ashwani said.

PROUD COACH

‘The way Nitish is sequencing the balls to the batters is helping him’



NAGARA GOPAL

It’s great to see Nitish Kumar play the way he’s been playing so far in this IPL. Last year, he probably, by his own admission, he didn’t quite play at the level he would have expected to. The pace is definitely up... the way he’s sequencing his balls to different batters is really helping him — SRH assistant coach James Franklin.

FIT FOR DUTY

The plan is for Cummins to play against RR on Saturday: Franklin



FILE PHOTO: K. MURALI KUMAR

SRH assistant coach James Franklin expects regular skipper Pat Cummins to be fit for the game against RR on Saturday. “That is the plan as far as I’m aware. He’s cleared all the scans that have been required of him from Cricket Australia. He rejoined a couple of days ago. The plan is for him to be available for the game in Jaipur”.

Tilak puts on a show as MI roars back with big win

The southpaw’s unbeaten 45-ball 101 powers the five-time champion to 199 for five; Ashwani impresses with a four-wicket haul while Santner and Ghazanfar claim two each to bowl out GT for 100

IPL-19

Shayan Acharya
AHMEDABAD

Tilak Varma found his form when it mattered most, producing a scintillating maiden IPL century to power Mumbai Indians to a commanding 99-run victory over Gujarat Titans on Monday. After a string of low scores, Tilak began cautiously before shifting gears dramatically, finishing unbeaten on 101 off 45 balls (8x4, 7x6). Much to the delight of a 40,000-strong crowd at the Narendra Modi Stadium, he went on the rampage in the final six overs, smashing 82 runs off just 23 deliveries. Mumbai Indians plundered 96 runs in that phase to post a formidable 199 for five and seize control of the contest. Tilak led the charge with ruthless precision, hammering 26 runs in an over from Ashok Sharma before dismantling Prasidh Krishna with calculated aggression. The southpaw reached his century with a boundary off the final ball of the



Perfect outing: Tilak could not have chosen a better occasion to notch up his maiden IPL century. Ashwani and Santner ensured there was no way back for GT. VIJAY SONEJI

innings, his animated celebration reflecting both relief and redemption. Emulating Jayasuriya He also equalled the joint-fastest hundred for MI, matching Sanath Jayasuri-

ya’s effort. In response, Titans faltered early and never recovered. Jasprit Bumrah struck with the very first ball, removing Sai Sudharsan, and the middle-order failed to deliver. With Jos Buttler

and Shubman Gill falling cheaply, the chase lost direction as wickets fell at regular intervals. The Titans were eventually bowled out for 100. It was a dominant show from the Mumbai bowlers.

Mitchell Santner marked his return with two key wickets, removing Washington Sundar and Glenn Phillips, while Impact Player Ashwani Kumar kept the pressure on with four wickets.

Earlier, MI began shakily. Debutant Danish Malewar lasted just four deliveries, while Quinton de Kock and Suryakumar Yadav also fell early, leaving it at 46 for three after the Power Play.

SCOREBOARD

MUMBAI INDIANS

Quinton de Kock c & b Rabada 13 (11b, 1x4, 1x6), Danish Malewar lbw b Rabada 2 (4b), Naman Dhir c Rabada b Prasidh 45 (32b, 6x4, 1x6), Suryakumar Yadav b Rabada 15 (10b, 1x4, 1x6), Tilak Varma (not out) 101 (45b, 8x4, 7x6), Hardik Pandya c Phillips b Siraj 15 (16b, 1x4), Sherfane Rutherford (not out) 1 (2b); Extras (b-1, lb-4, w-2): 7; Total (for five wkts. in 20 overs): 199.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-10 (Malewar, 1.5 overs), 2-25 (de Kock, 3.3), 3-44 (Suryakumar, 5.5), 4-96 (Naman, 12.3), 5-177 (Hardik, 18.5).

TITANS BOWLING

Siraj 4-0-25-1, Rabada 4-0-33-3, Ashok 3-0-38-0, Rashid 4-0-31-0, Prasidh 4-0-54-1, Washington 1-0-13-0.

GUJARAT TITANS

Sai Sudharsan c Bhagat b Bumrah 0 (1b), Shubman Gill c Naman b Ashwani 14 (13b, 3x4), Jos Buttler lbw b Hardik 5 (6b, 1x4), Washington Sundar c Naman b Santner 26 (17b, 5x4), Glenn Phillips c & b Santner 6 (8b), Rahul Tewatia (Impact Player for Prasidh) c de Kock b Ashwani 8 (11b, 1x4), Shahrukh

Khan c Naman b Ashwani 17 (13b, 1x4, 1x6), Rashid Khan c sub (Bawa) b Ashwani 4 (6b), Kagiso Rabada st. de Kock b Ghazanfar 12 (14b, 2x4), Ashok Sharma (not out) 1 (3b), Mohammed Siraj lbw b Ghazanfar 0 (3b); Extras (w-7): 7; Total (in 15.5 overs): 100.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-0 (Sai Sudharsan, 0.1), 2-5 (Buttler, 1.2), 3-40 (Gill, 4.4), 4-54 (Washington, 7.2), 5-55 (Phillips, 7.4), 6-79 (Tewatia, 10.6), 7-85 (Rashid, 12.2), 8-86 (Shahrukh, 12.6), 9-99 (Rabada, 15.2).

MUMBAI INDIANS BOWLING

Bumrah 3-0-15-1, Hardik 1-0-18-1, Bhagat 2-0-10-0, Ashwani (Impact Player for Rutherford) 4-0-24-4, Ghazanfar 2.5-0-17-2, Santner 3-0-16-2.

Toss: Gujarat Titans.

Player-of-the-Match: Tilak. Mumbai Indians won by 99 runs.

Next assignment

- MI:

April 23 vs. CSK
Mumbai, 7.30 p.m.
- GT:

April 24 vs. RCB
Bengaluru, 7.30 p.m.

Clash of contrasting styles as SRH takes on DC

Vivek Krishnan
HYDERABAD

Distinct philosophies will be at work when Sunrisers Hyderabad hosts Delhi Capitals in an IPL-19 fixture at the Rajiv Gandhi International Stadium here on Tuesday. If Sunrisers’ modus operandi with the willow gravitates towards belligerence from the very outset, Capitals’ approach tends to be more measured and in sync with the situation. These divergent methods have yielded similar results this season. With three wins and as many losses, SRH has collected six points from six outings. Capitals also have six points, with their five matches comprising three wins and two defeats. Spirits should be high in both camps after their most recent outings ended in triumph. From DC’s perspective, it was essential to ensure that a run of two straight defeats was nipped in the bud. It managed to do so by sneaking past Royal Challengers Bengaluru in the Garden City on Saturday. Truth be told, Axar Patel’s men nearly bungled a chase of 176, but the fact that David Miller got them over the line in the final over must have been a source of relief. The South African had been on the bitter end



Talking cricket: SRH’s Harshal and DC’s Axar share a light moment during practice. NAGARA GOPAL

Today’s match



Hyderabad, 7.30 p.m.

HEAD-TO-HEAD

Played: 26

SRH 13 | DC 12 | NR 1

MEETINGS IN 2025

No Result

DC won by seven wickets

LIVE ON STAR SPORTS 1 & JOHOTSTAR

of a taut chase against Gujarat Titans not long ago. Just as comforting for Capitals is the news that Axar is fit after retiring hurt on 26 against RCB due to

cramps. “He is fine and ready,” DC head coach Hemang Badani said. For the host, the batting is firing on all cylinders again. That Abhishek Sharma is back to his marauding best is a good sign, and with Ishan Kishan and Heinrich Klaasen also producing innings of substance, the top-order is in fine shape. On the bowling front, SRH has veered towards youthful zest by reposing faith in the pace pair of Praful Hinge and Sakib Hussain and left-arm wrist-spinner Shivang Kumar. Will SRH’s unbridled aggression hold sway? Or will Capitals’ relative pragmatism prevail?

Miller has shown character after heartbreak: Badani

Vivek Krishnan
HYDERABAD

In two games spread across 10 days in this IPL, David Miller’s output as a finisher has generated markedly contrasting outcomes. If he was chastised for his failure to lead Delhi Capitals to victory against Gujarat Titans on April 8, he was celebrated for his boundary-laden exploits against Royal Challengers Bengaluru last Saturday. DC’s one-run defeat to GT polarised opinion, especially because Miller had a chance to secure a tie off the penultimate ball. With two runs needed off two deliveries, the southpaw refused an easy single on offer in an attempt to get the job done off his own bat. The decision stung as he failed to make contact off the final ball. It is a testament to the 36-year-old’s vast experience that he was able to brush the disappointment aside when confronted with a nervy chase against RCB. DC coach Hemang Badani said on Monday that he concurred with Miller’s call against Titans. “First and foremost, we need to understand that



Rabada consoles Miller after the DC-GT match. FILE PHOTO: SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

he’s somebody who’s been around for a very long time. Yes, it’s heartbreaking to lose a game like the one we lost against Gujarat. “And there was enough chatter about it on social media, on the news, on the telly and even by the broadcaster. But the bottom line is that the player takes a call at some time,” Badani said. ‘Right call’ “And sometimes you get the right call, sometimes you don’t get the right call. And I still believe that he took the right call. But to come out of that, he’s shown character”.

It’s all about understanding what works for you: Connolly

Dhruva Prasad
NEW CHANDIGARH

In Punjab Kings’ thrill-a-minute batting line-up, which posted this IPL season’s highest total on Sunday, Cooper Connolly’s approach strikes a discordant note. The 22-year-old Australian doesn’t attempt to manufacture those cheeky shots that have become synonymous with T20 cricket but rather relies on his gift of timing and placement. Neither does he try to force the pace of the game. During his 182-run stand with the belligerent Priyansh Arya, he bided his time in the PowerPlay before finishing with a 46-ball 87 that helped Kings to a match-winning 254 for seven against Lucknow Super Giants. “Everyone has their own understanding of their ability and how they go about it, and what works for them. “It is about individually understanding what works for you in those moments and what makes you successful for a long period of time. We have discussions about what works for each other, and we take little things from each other’s books,” Connolly said, while adding that he was enjoying watching Priyansh “go about it in his



Touch player: Connolly relies on his gift of timing and placement. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Points table

	M	W	L	NR	PTS	NRR
Punjab Kings	6	5	0	1	11	1.420
Royal Challengers	6	4	2	0	8	1.171
Rajasthan Royals	6	4	2	0	8	0.599
Sunrisers Hyderabad	6	3	3	0	6	0.566
Delhi Capitals	5	3	2	0	6	0.310
Gujarat Titans	6	3	3	0	6	-0.821
Mumbai Indians	6	2	4	0	4	0.067
Chennai Super Kings	6	2	4	0	4	-0.780
Lucknow Super Giants	6	2	4	0	4	-1.173
Kolkata Knight Riders	7	1	5	1	3	-0.879

own way” from the non-striker’s end. For Connolly, who tops the run chart for Kings with 223 runs in five innings, “there is a time and a place” for innovative stroke-making. “I think it’s about knowing their (the batters’) strengths and sticking to them. They know where they’re dominant,” Connolly said about the diffe-

rent approaches of the Kings batters. It was a similar case of backing his strengths and ability for Super Giants pacer Prince Yadav, who bowled a stingy spell (two for 25 in four overs) in a match that saw more than 450 runs being plundered. “The plan was to bowl as many yorkers as I could; it is something I have been working on”.

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RO No. 02/DP/MCD/2026-27 Commercial Officer, Advertisement Department, MCD

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			Closing	Opening
1	2026178110001 Dated : 20.04.2026	Supply & Installation of Hardware Upgradation of SAP S/4 HANA 1809 to 2025, version gration of existing SAP system on turnkey basis, including Post implementation Hardware & Software Support at Integral Coach Factory, Chennai - 600 038.	18.05.2026 15.00 Hrs	18.05.2026 15.30 Hrs.

Website for submission of offer : www.ireps.gov.in

INDIAN RAILWAYS
PATIALA LOCOMOTIVE WORKS
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Notice inviting Electronic Tenders

On behalf of President of India Principal Chief Materials Manager/PLW/Patiala invites tenders in electronic form for following items:
e-Tender Notice No. 03 ET/2026-27

SN	Tender No.	Description	Qty.	Tender closing date
1	20261049	Machine Room Blower	193 Nos.	11.05.2026*
2	20261055	Main Compressor	380 Sets	20.05.2026**
3	01261022	Hydraulically Operated Lifting and Swiveling Platform	11 Nos.	12.05.2026***
4	20261058	Brake Control System	179 Sets	28.05.2026**
5	20261056	Supply, Installation and Commissioning of Electrically Operated Wind Screen Wiper Assembly	81 Sets	18.05.2026
6	21261047	Complete Panel A & D	289 Sets	18.05.2026
7	11265037A	VVVF Drive Complete Bogie Testing Plant	01 Nos.	14.05.2026

Tender closing time 15:00 Hrs
Item marked with * is reserved for procurement from CLW approved sources.
Item marked with ** is reserved for procurement from RDSO approved sources.
Item marked with *** is reserved for procurement from ICF approved sources.
The prospective Tenderers are advised to visit the website <http://www.ireps.gov.in> or <http://www.plw.indianrailways.gov.in> for detailed description of items & other terms and conditions of tender document. Please note that Tenderers can submit their quotations only through <http://www.ireps.gov.in>.
Corrigendum to e-Tender Notice No. 48 ET/2025-26
Closing date of Tender No.20261025 may be read as 27.04.2026. 1293/2026

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FURNITURE ALL SOFAS, All Recliners,Recondition, Reupholstery KNS Rajan 7667133233	PUBLIC NOTICE NOTICE TO MEMBERS / CREDITORS (Under Section 17(4) of MSCS Act, 2002) Date: 20.04.2026 To All Members & Creditors of Bharat Petroleum Employees' Co-operative Society Ltd. Subject: Notice of Proposed Merger and Invitation for Claims/Objections Notice is hereby given that the Society has passed a resolution dated 27.09.2024 proposing merger with The Miller Co-operative Credit Society Ltd. under Section 17 of the Multi-State Co-operative Societies Act, 2002. In compliance with Section 17(4) of the Act: Any member or creditor may, within 30 days from the date of receipt/ publication of this notice, withdraw their shares / deposits / loans or raise objections, if any. All claims/ objections, if any, shall be submitted in writing to the Society at the following Address: BHARAT PETROLEUM EMPLOYEES' CO-OPERATIVE SOCIETY LTD., No.1, Ranganathan Gardens, Anna Nagar, Chennai - 600040 Email (optional): bharatpetroleumccsro@gmail.com Contact No.: 9444130686 If no claims/objections are received within the stipulated period of 30 days, it shall be presumed that: ✓ The member/creditor has no objection to the proposed merger ✓ No claims/dues are pending This notice is issued in compliance with Section 17(4) of the MSCS Act, 2002. By Order of the Bharat Petroleum Employees' Co-operative Society Ltd., JUDHAYAKUMAR President
HOME NEEDS Parryware always in fashion BATHROOM RENOVATION From Professional Bathroom Makers Since 2001 FRIENDLY SERVICES Call Now: 044-2432 3144 98412-95033 98412-78121 T.Nagar, Chennai - 600 017.	TENDERS Repco Home Finance We value your Dream "RHFL Invites Quotations for the Empanelment of Vendors for the Purchase and Installation of Desktop for branches across Pan India of Repco Home Finance Ltd". Last date for submission of bid is on 04.05.2026 (5.00 p.m.) For further details and application procedure, visit our website www.repcohome.com
PUBLIC NOTICE OFFERS ARE invited in sealed covers for lease of property, namely, land situated in 13.92 grounds, be- longing to Estate of John Demonte, comprised in Plot No. 27, Door No. 135 and New Door No. 138, Plot No. 28 in Door No.136, Plot No. 27, Old door No. 19, New Door No. 39, Plot No. 29 Old Door No. 18, New Door No. 37, Demonte Colony, St. Marys Road, Alwarpet, Chennai- 600018 comprised in S.No. 3676 part, Block No.73, Mylapore Vi- lage, Triplicane-Mylapore Taluk, Chennai District, Corporation of Chennai, bounded on the North by: Land belonging to Estate of John Demonte, South by: St. Marys Road, Alwarpet, Chennai- 600018 comprised in S.No. 3676 part, Block No.73, Mylapore Vi- lage, Triplicane-Mylapore Taluk, Chennai District, Corporation of Chennai, bounded on the North by: Land belonging to Estate of John Demonte, South by: St. Marys Road, Alwarpet, Chennai- 600018 comprised in S.No. 3676 part, Block No.73, Mylapore Vi- lage, Triplicane-Mylapore Taluk, Chennai District, 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ஸ்டாலின் அரசின் ஐந்தாண்டு சாதனைகள்



Ulagam Ungal Kaiyil

Laptops for 20 Lakh college students

Pongal Gift

Rs. 3,000 Pongal gift for 2.22 Crore families

Women's Self-Help Groups

Rs. 1.42 Lakh Cr in loans, Rs. 2,119.23 Cr debt waiver

Rs. 5,000 for Women

Rs.3000 Kalaingar Magalir Urimai Thogai and
Rs.2000 Special summer relief package for **1.31crore** women

Makkalai Thedi Maruthuvam

Doorstep medical services to 2.64 Crore people

Housing Patta

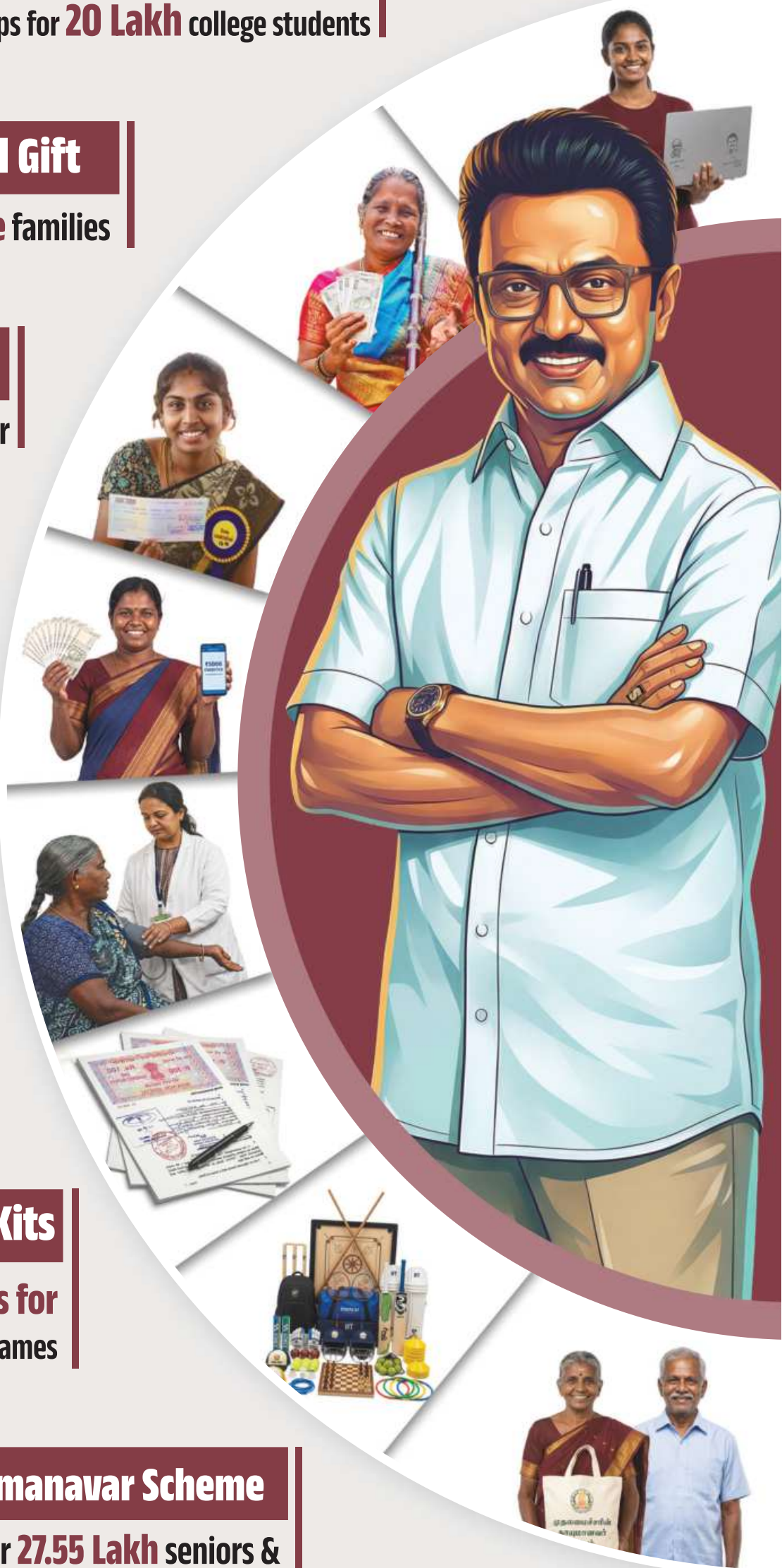
Housing pattas for 23 Lakh people across Tamilnadu

Doctor Kalaingar Sports Kits

**16,798 sports kits for
33 games**

Thayumanavar Scheme

Doorstep ration products for 27.55 Lakh seniors & differently abled



Investments & Jobs

Rs.12.16 Lakh Cr
investment
36 Lakh jobs



**வாக்களிப்பீர்
உதயசூரியன்**

23 ஏப்ரல்



வாக்களிப்பீர் உதயசூரியன்



**ஸ்டாலின் தொடரட்டும்..
தமிழ்நாடு வெல்லட்டும்!**



I watched the 2013 match from behind a glass wall... glad I have made it inside

Candidates winner and World championship challenger Vaishali credits her support system for making remarkable turnarounds in big-ticket events; she says meticulous preparation with her team played a big part in her success in Cyprus

FIDE

INTERVIEW

R. Vaishali

P.K. Ajith Kumar

She staged a coup in Cyprus. R. Vaishali, seeded eighth in a field of eight, won the women's Candidates chess tournament, the qualifying event for the World championship match. The 24-year-old from Chennai is the first Indian to do so in the 74-year history of the Candidates. Excerpts:

What are your thoughts on the World title match against Ju Wenjun later this year?

I watched a World championship match from behind a glass wall in Chennai in 2013. It was the match between

Viswanathan Anand sir and Magnus Carlsen. I was just a kid then. I was dreaming of playing and winning the World championship even those days.

Interestingly, D. Gukesh, the reigning World champion, had also watched that match live...

Yes, I am glad that we had the match in Chennai. Many chess players, when they were kids, were able to follow it. I am sure many kids, like me, dreamt of being there inside that glass hall.

How did you prepare for the Candidates?

I had back-to-back camps with my team, and I didn't play any tournaments for three or four months. All that preparation definitely helped me a lot. When you work a lot, you get a lot of confidence. In some of the games here, I got to play the lines that we prepared for.

I had been defending in almost every game.

But in the second half, you played superbly. What would you attribute that to?

I started to focus on the quality of my games. And I wanted to play good games.

There seems to be a pattern. You go through a tough phase, you then bounce back strongly, winning several games in a row. It happened at your first Candidates too – after starting not so well in Toronto, you won your last five games to be tied for second place.

Yes, this has always been the pattern for me in tournaments. After I hit the absolute low, I peak. And that has been the case throughout my career.

Even when you were a kid, in age-group tournaments?

Mostly, yes. But I was mostly winning my events.

So how do you manage these remarkable turnarounds during a tournament?

I have to thank the people around me. They motivate me. It is because of their support – my family, my trainers.

Looking back at the Candidates, you must be pleased with the way you scored that crushing win over Kateryna Lagno in the must-win final round. That victory gave you the title. So it was probably the most important game of your career so far...

Definitely. I am very happy that with all the pressure around, I managed to play such a controlled game. I was better throughout.

You hardly gave her a chance. You kept that pressure on...

Yes. I didn't expect her to play the Dragon variation, but I had prepared for it before the tournament, and it helped me. The situation was that if she won, she had some chances (of finishing first). The field was wide open and anybody could have won. She was also in a situation where she could have played for more. And that provoked

her to play a very aggressive line like Dragon. And I was very happy to see some Sicilian on the board. Because it is very nice to get a fighting position.

Were you keeping an eye on Bibisara Assaubayeva's game with Divya Deshmukh? If Bibisara had won, there would have been a tie-breaker...

Yes, here and there. Because it was tough not to follow it. When I got the advantageous position, I made sure I focused more on my game. Because it felt like it was in my hands. Anyway, I had to win, no matter what happened in the other game.

Before that, you scored a crucial win against Divya. You must have been glad with the way you finished that game, with the exchange sacrifice...

It was satisfying. I felt like I was outplaying her from the beginning. I also liked my game against Aleksandra Goryachkina with black pieces, because it is not easy to outplay her. You do not see her losing with white like that. It was a very interesting game. Also, it is not the way I usually win games. The queens were off the board after 13 moves. And it was a positional game.

You must have been delighted that coach R.B. Ramesh reached Cyprus just in time for the closing ceremony...

Yes. Pragg and I have been working with him for the last 12 years. It has been a long journey. We have seen many victories as well as some tough tournaments together. He had promised us that he would come to Cyprus if we won the Candidates. He had to cancel some of his training camps to come here.

Pragg was also in Cyprus, playing in the Open section. Did you discuss your games with him?

We talked about how things were going every day. For my last couple of games, we discussed what openings I could play. I also had a team that was helping me throughout. Of course it was also nice to have him with me. It was a very tough tournament for him, but I am sure he will come back strong.

How much of a help has the WestBridge Anand Chess Academy (WACA) been to you?

A lot of credit must be given to WACA, which has been supporting me for many years now. The last few years have not been easy; there were some tough tournaments, but WACA has continued to help me in every way possible. The support was incredible because for a tournament like this, you need back-to-back camps and things like that. What WACA has been doing for Indian chess is remarkable.

For the last five or six years, it has been a great journey.

Anand is a mentor at WACA...

He gives you confidence. Even having a small chat with him helps. Ahead of the Candidates, we had a session in which I discussed some of the lines that I played here.

Koneru Humpy is the only Indian to play a women's World championship match so far, and you are going to be the second to do so. Your thoughts on Humpy's contribution to women's chess in India?

It is amazing. Humpy and D. Harika have been playing for decades now. And they are still among the world's top players.

Humpy won her second World rapid crown two years ago...

She was close to winning it last year too. It is inspiring to see what she does every time. Winning a tournament is not easy. You can play, but it is tough to win a tournament every time. She is also a mother, and she is balancing her career with her family duties; so does Harika. I have a lot of respect for both of them. My love and respect for them just keeps on growing.

And they were playing when women's chess wasn't anywhere near as popular as it is today.

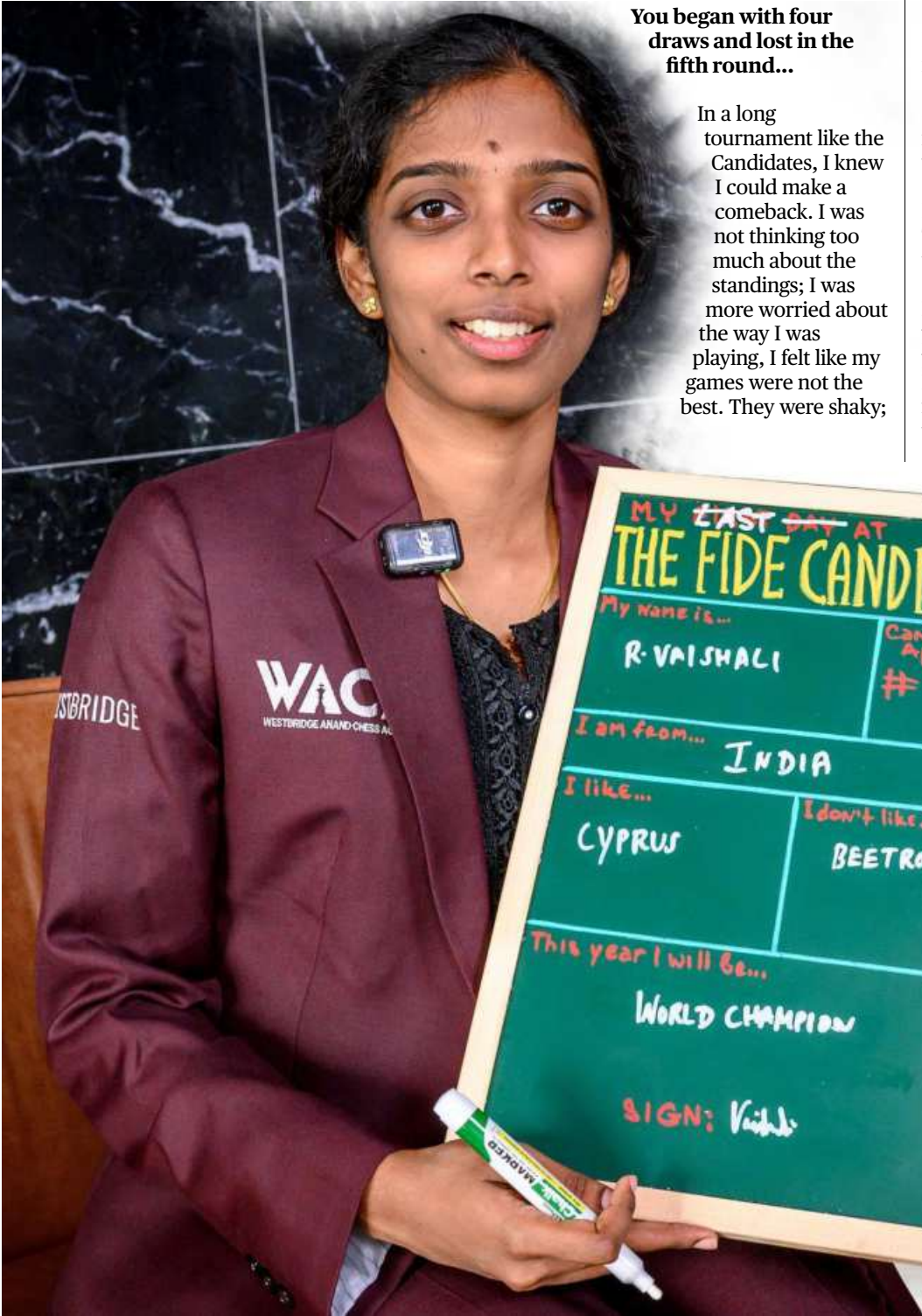
Yes, there was no attention. And now we have so many girls coming up, playing chess and becoming professionals. We are just following their path.

How much of a support has your family been?

I am very happy that my mother was with me throughout the tournament (Candidates). And my father has also made a lot of sacrifices. Since Pragg, our mother and I are travelling most of the time for our tournaments, he has to live alone.

You had a lot of backing from your school, Velammal, as well...

Definitely, I studied there from LKG to Std. XII. They were of great help to me and Pragg. It is not easy to be a professional player, and we had some financial issues at the beginning. Velammal gave us free education and cash awards at the right time. They also helped with flight tickets for some tournaments. I have also received a lot of help from Venkatrama Raja sir of Ramco Cements. He continues to support me and I had met him to seek his blessings for the Candidates. I was one of the kids sent by Velammal for Anand sir's reception at the Chennai airport after his triumph against Boris Gelfand sir in the 2012 World title match. Anand sir has always been a huge inspiration for me. Pragg has also inspired me.



You began with four draws and lost in the fifth round...

In a long tournament like the Candidates, I knew I could make a comeback. I was not thinking too much about the standings; I was more worried about the way I was playing. I felt like my games were not the best. They were shaky;

Long UPSC prep cycles take a toll on aspirants’ mental health

The psychological experience of preparing for UPSC examination differs from other competitive examinations, including JEE for IITs and NEET for medical education, because aspirants typically prepare for the exam for several years, which leads to chronic rather than short-term stress

Rohan Singh
Neeraj Kumar Singh

For lakhs of young Indians, the national civil services examination is not just a test: it becomes part of who they are. More than 10 lakh aspirants take the examination every year. Many spend several years preparing, often relocating to coaching hubs such as Delhi and Hyderabad.

With only around a thousand positions on offer, the examination is among the world’s most competitive. Experts are concerned that this prolonged, high-stakes process is also reshaping aspirants’ sense of self.

For many aspirants, preparation is marked by long hours of study and constant anxiety about outcomes. One aspirant who requested anonymity said the uncertainty is worse than the workload: “My biggest fear is not performing to my full potential despite consistent effort.”

Hidden psychological cost

Passing the qualifying exam for the Union Public Services Commission (UPSC) comes with a sustained form of psychological strain. In a 2024 study involving UPSC aspirants, Madiha Fatima, PhD scholar and senior research fellow at the University of Lucknow’s Department of Psychology, found that 70% of aspirants reported moderate to severe distress.

“The pressure of uncertainty whether one will qualify, the vast syllabus, fear of forgetting, and the ever-changing exam pattern all contribute,” she said.

Persistent self-doubt, she added, often leaves aspirants questioning whether they are capable or simply wasting their time.

“Privileged students don’t face the same stress. Underprivileged aspirants struggle to afford courses or materials. Some work part-time, reducing rest and study time,” Ms. Fathima said.

Years of repeated failures also erode self-confidence, leading to avoidance and isolation that affects psychological health. She pointed to delayed answer keys, unpredictable paper patterns, and the vast seat-to-aspirant gap as structural stressors.

According to independent psychiatrist A.K. Mishra, such prolonged identification reshapes how aspirants perceive setbacks: “Aspirants often begin to anchor their sense of self-worth almost entirely around the examination.”

Chronic stress, burnout

The psychological experience of preparing for the UPSC examination differs from other competitive examinations, including the Joint Entrance Examination (JEE) for the IITs and the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET) for medical education. This is because aspirants typically prepare for the UPSC exam for several years, which leads to chronic rather than short-term stress.

According to Dr. Mishra, such protracted preparation shifts stress from an acute phase to a persistent background state of cognitive load, decision fatigue, and reduced recovery. He also said prolonged uncertainty can produce “chronic anticipatory stress”, where repeated attempts without success diminish the individual’s sense of control and also contribute to emotional exhaustion.



Civil service aspirants wait outside an examination centre as they arrive to appear for the UPSC preliminary exam, in Jammu, in March 2026. ANI

Abhishek Pathak, a psychiatrist in Lucknow, also said long-term preparation shares features with chronic stress and burnout. Prolonged uncertainty can lead to “anticipatory anxiety and identity fusion.” However, he noted that the impact is bidirectional – it enhances risks in some people and promotes growth in others – and that early support can mitigate adverse outcomes.

Prolonged uncertainty is particularly challenging for young adults in their 20s, a phase typically associated with career formation and financial independence. When many years in this stage of life are instead devoted to a single exam, the stakes can become intensely personal.

Why the dream endures

Psychology alone can’t explain the toll that preparing for the UPSC exam takes. Sociologists have argued that the appeal of the civil services is rooted in India’s social structure, where the bureaucracy has long held authority and prestige and families widely perceive the services to be a path to upward mobility.

South Asian University sociologist Sumedha Dutta traced this aspiration to the colonial origins of India’s civil services. After independence, the prestige that came with a member of the civil services, including the high salary, job security, housing, and pension, remained intact. “Civil servants are part of the power elite,” she said.

The yearning for government jobs didn’t decline even in the post-liberalisation era even as the private sector burgeoned. “Private sector jobs, despite high salaries, do not match up in terms of stability, numerous perks, pension, power, and prestige,” Dr. Dutta said.

She pointed to matrimonial advertisements where civil servants rank highly, plus the media’s role in valorising successful aspirants, as factors that reinforce the exam’s status in the collective imagination.

The aspirant ecosystem surrounding the exam in fact reflects this collective aspiration. Entire neighbourhoods in

THE PRESSURE OF UNCERTAINTY

The pressure of uncertainty whether one will qualify, the vast syllabus, fear of forgetting, and the ever-changing exam pattern all contribute

MADIHA FATIMA
Senior research fellow at the University of Lucknow

Delhi and Prayagraj are dedicated to coaching institutes, libraries, and hostels, forming a parallel education economy.

Among them, coaching institutes – while they are central to this ecosystem – remain largely unexamined in shaping or mitigating psychological distress. The aspirant quoted earlier said, “Coaching centres benefit financially from prolonged preparation cycles. There is no accountability, no oversight.”

Within this ecosystem, aspirants form tightly knit peer groups and share educational materials, attend lectures together, and discuss current affairs late into the night. While these networks offer support, they can also intensify pressure through constant comparison. As Dr. Dutta said, this in-group solidarity is also shaped by a sense of collective superiority.

“UPSC aspirants already envision themselves as part of the elite group which runs the administration of the nation state,” she explained. “They believe other career pathways are ‘mere professions’ while civil servants are the ones who decide the fate of other professionals in many ways.”

This shared imagination of a secure, prestigious future, she added, can also help aspirants navigate the hardships that come with prolonged preparation.

Inside the system

Psychologists have stressed that while ambition and perseverance are valuable, preparation ecosystems must also recognise the emotional risks of prolonged uncertainty. Access to counselling, peer support, and realistic

career guidance could help reduce this burden.

Harivansh Chaturvedi, director-general of the Institute of Integrated Learning in Management, New Delhi, said that while many aspirants spend years preparing, doing so reflects individual choice within a highly aspirational system rather than a purely systemic failure. However, he acknowledged that unsuccessful attempts can still result in significant personal loss of time and effort.

To this end, he suggested faster evaluation, more frequent preliminary exams, streamlined selection, and specialised undergraduate programmes aligned with public administration.

Ms. Fatima said most research studies have been descriptive: they have identified problems, not solutions. She also argued that the scale of aspiration needs rethinking and suggested encouraging youth towards other professions or startups.

Dr. Mishra added that preparation could, over time, take a maladaptive form in some cases, particularly when it loses flexibility and proportionality. “Key indicators include persistent distress, neglect of alternative roles, inability to reassess goals, and compulsive continuation driven by fear of disengagement,” he said.

At the same time, sociologists argue that the popularity of the civil services exam reflects deeper structural issues in India’s employment landscape. Dr. Dutta said the UPSC ecosystem “unravels India’s development inadequacies”. Rising GDP hasn’t matched jobs, the informal sector offers little security, and there is a major skill gap.

For many graduates, particularly from smaller towns, the civil services thus remain one of a few career options seen as both prestigious and secure.

*(Rohan Singh is an independent science journalist in Lucknow. Rohanthakur780@gmail.com
Dr. Neeraj Kumar Singh is Head, Lucknow Public College of Professional Studies, Lucknow. dr.neeraj.lpcps@gmail.com)*



Sundarbans is the largest contiguous mangrove forest in the world. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

Sundarbans may be less blue than it seems

Vasudevan Mukunth

Researchers from the Indian Institute of Science Education and Research (IISER), Kolkata, have reported that microplastics could interfere with the natural food web and alter the carbon budget of the Bay of Bengal.

As microplastics weather and break down, they leach dissolved organic carbon into the water; the microbes living on the plastic also create ‘biogenic’ carbon, the team reported in a paper due to be published in the May 2026 issue of the *Journal of Hazardous Materials Advances*.

The authors conducted a year-long study to understand how small plastic particles move through the ecosystem and how they might interfere with natural carbon cycles.

The Sundarbans is the world’s largest contiguous mangrove forest. Because it sits at the confluence of major rivers like the Ganga and the Brahmaputra, a large amount of waste generated upstream is also carried into the delta.

As microplastics break down in water, they release dissolved organic carbon, which can be food for bacteria to grow and multiply much faster than they would naturally

While scientists have known that the area is polluted, they have lacked detailed information on how microplastics behave in the surface water across different seasons and how much carbon they contribute to the environment.

Between October 2021 and October 2022, the IISER Kolkata collected water samples twice a month from three locations near Sagar Island in the Mooriganga estuary, then used advanced laboratory techniques to identify the types of plastic and observe how the particles were breaking down.

This way, the team uncovered a high concentration of microplastics, ranging from about 5 particles per liter to over 58 particles per liter. Their levels were around 40% higher during the monsoon season because, the researchers concluded, heavy rainfall washed plastic waste from the land and urban drains into the estuary. In these months, they also found a surge in what they called “colourless fragments” – likely older, weathered pieces of plastic being moved by surface runoff.

Around half of the plastics were fibres, likely from textiles, followed by fragments. The most common materials were polypropylene, which is used in packaging, and polyethylene terephthalate, used to make water bottles.

High-resolution imaging revealed that the microplastics were not clean but had cracks, pits, and grooves, suggesting that they were breaking down into even smaller nanoplastics. The researchers also found plastispheres, which are complex communities of bacteria and microbes living on the surface of the plastic.

Crucially, because the plastics are roughly 90% carbon, they were acting as a “novel carbon reservoir”, the researchers wrote in their paper. As microplastics break down in water, they release dissolved organic carbon, which can be food for bacteria to grow and multiply much faster than they would naturally. The life-forms growing on the plastic were producing carbon of their own, called biogenic carbon.

Mangroves are blue-carbon ecosystems, meaning they are efficient at capturing and storing carbon dioxide from the atmosphere. However, the authors added, the introduction of carbon in the form of plastics could render them less efficient. Microplastics in the Sundarbans are now a significant part of the ecosystem’s carbon cycle.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’

THE SCIENCE QUIZ

Where rivers and cities meet

Vasudevan Mukunth

QUESTION 1

The name of this city in Arabic means “elephant’s trunk” — which it earned because it is located in a peninsula shaped in this way, formed by the merging of the blue-green Blue Nile and the muddier White Nile. Which city is this?

QUESTION 2

_____ in Peru is the world’s largest city that is inaccessible by road yet which is also not an island. It has a population of around 5 lakh. It is also called the Peruvian Amazon and lies at the convergence of the Amazon, Itaya, and Nanay rivers. Fill in the blank.

QUESTION 3

A major node in the trans-Saharan trade from the 13th to the 16th centuries, _____ lies at the point where the Niger river reaches its northernmost arc into the desert. Back then, it was where traders exchanged West African gold and salt; it also housed three large mosques and several Islamic universities. Fill in the blank.

QUESTION 4

The city of X lies 1,500 km inland from the Atlantic Ocean, at the confluence of the Negro and Amazon rivers. It grew rapidly during the rubber boom of the late 19th and early 20th centuries, when it briefly became one of the wealthiest cities in South America. Name X.

QUESTION 5

This city has been continuously inhabited since around 1200 BC. It lies on the west bank of a river, at the point where the river bends towards the north. This bend is significant in Hindu cosmology and the city has been a centre of religious pilgrimage throughout its history. Name it.



VISUAL: Name this iconic city of 32 million in China located where the Jialing and Yangtze rivers come together. DAVID290 (CC BY-SA)

Please send in your answers to science@thehindu.co.in

Answers to April 16 quiz:

1. Tree whose outer bark peels off at different times of year – **Ans: Rainbow eucalyptus**
2. “Upside down” tree that excels at storing water – **Ans: Baobab**
3. Property of Jabuticaba tree due to which its fruits grow on the trunk – **Ans: Cauliflorous**
4. Colony of quaking aspens in Utah that is a single organism – **Ans: Pando**
5. Tree with stilt-like roots that allows it to ‘walk’ – **Ans: Walking palm**

Visual: Methuselah
First contact: K.N. Viswanathan | Tamal Biswas | Prem Nath Tiwari | Anmol Agrawal

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Persons arrested in Türkiye with suspected links to IS

90 Türkiye on Monday said it had arrested 90 people with suspected links to the Islamic State jihadist group, two weeks after a deadly shoot-out outside the Israeli consulate in Istanbul. A total of 198 people were detained a day after the April 7 attack in a nationwide sweep against “the terrorist organisation Daesh”, another name for the Islamic State. AFP

Percentage contraction in core sector output in March

0.4 in per cent. The core sector output contracted by 0.4% in March, marking the first decline in five months as production of coal, crude oil, fertilizer, and electricity fell, according to official data. In February 2026, the eight core infrastructure sectors had expanded by 2.8%. In 2025-26, these sectors recorded a growth rate of 2.6% as against 4.5% in 2024-25. PTI

Department of Post’s revenue for the financial year 2025-26

15,296 in ₹ crore. The Dept. of Posts has clocked revenue of ₹15,296 crore for the financial year 2025-26, a 16% growth year-on-year, Communications Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia said on Monday. Announcing the revenue scorecard, Mr. Scindia said the year has been “historic” for the department. PTI

Share of candidates in fray in T.N. elections with criminal cases

18 in per cent. According to a report by the Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR), out of the 3,992 candidates analysed, 722 (18%) candidates have declared criminal cases against themselves. Of these, 404 (10%) have declared serious criminal cases. In 2021, out of 3,559 candidates analysed, 466 (13%) had declared criminal cases against themselves. PTI

Death toll from the Virudhunagar firecracker unit blast

25 With most bodies charred beyond recognition, identification remains difficult, police said on Monday, as the toll in the massive explosion at a fireworks unit near Kattannarpatti here rose to 25. The Virudhunagar district administration has announced ₹5.5 lakh *ex gratia* to the kin of the deceased. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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U.S. power, Latin American resistance

The U.S.’s increasingly aggressive and coercive approach in Latin America echoes earlier periods of intervention and gunboat diplomacy; this stance is likely to fuel a resurgence of anti-imperialist thinking and resistance across the region

WORLD INSIGHT

Tony Wood

In Latin America, as in other parts of the world, the second Donald Trump administration has adopted an increasingly aggressive policy.

From drone strikes on purported drug traffickers to increased tariffs on imports, and from the blockade on fuel shipments and threats of invasion in Cuba to the January 3 military incursion into Venezuela, the U.S.’s more coercive approach to its hemispheric neighbours evokes an earlier period of U.S. foreign policy.

Many commentators have found echoes of the 1989 capture of Panamanian leader Manuel Noriega in the kidnapping of Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro. Others highlighted the longer history of U.S. interventions in Latin America, stretching back through the Cold War. That includes the Nixon administration’s support for the 1973 coup against Salvador Allende in Chile or the CIA-sponsored removal of Guatemala’s elected president, Jacobo Arbenz, in 1954.

Yet as a historian of early 20th-century Latin America, I believe the Trump administration’s approach to Latin America more closely resembles an older pattern of U.S. policy. Between 1900 and the mid-1930s, U.S. forces intervened in one Latin American country after another. This practice was often justified by the Roosevelt Corollary, President Theodore Roosevelt’s addition to the Monroe Doctrine. In cases of “chronic wrongdoing,” Roosevelt said in 1904, the U.S. would find itself compelled to exercise an “international police power” in defence of U.S. interests.

But crucially, how Latin Americans responded to the U.S. exerting its dominance in the early 20th century may hold some lessons for the present day. One of the major side effects of the U.S.’s so-called gunboat diplomacy was an upsurge of resistance and anti-imperialist thinking in the region’s political life.

The roots of anti-imperialism

In the 30 years after Roosevelt asserted the U.S.’s right to intervene across the hemisphere, U.S. forces occupied Cuba three times – in 1906-09, 1912, and 1917-21. They also occupied Haiti from 1915 to 1934 and the Dominican Republic from 1916 to 1924. In Nicaragua, the U.S. deployed the Marines from 1912 to 1925 and then again from 1926 to 1933, waging a counterinsurgency in which it used aerial bombardment for the first time.

Across much of the region, then, this was a time when the U.S. was quick to resort to force, unburdened by any concerns for Latin American countries’ sovereignty.

Yet this era of external intervention also coincided with a period of remarkable political ferment, which I describe in my recently published book, *Radical Sovereignty*.

In one place after another, from Buenos Aires to Mexico City and from Havana to Lima, movements sprang up that put forward sharp critiques of U.S. power. Many of them grew out of student organisations in the late 1910s, while others drew on the rising strength of labour unions and newly formed leftist political parties.

In 1923, rural workers in the Mexican state of Veracruz formed a Peasant League. From the outset, they saw local issues as closely interwoven with international ones, and they argued that



In one voice: A protester carrying a sign reading ‘Trump, Latin America is not yours,’ as demonstrators oppose U.S. actions in Venezuela. FILE PHOTO

there was a compelling reason for this. As the league put it, “Our internationalism is not the child of a crazed enthusiasm for empty phrases... but of the need to take preventive measures, to bolster ourselves against the enemy,” which they identified as “the imperialism of North America.”

Many of Latin America’s radical movements at this time were inspired by the recent example of the Mexican Revolution. The new Mexican Constitution of 1917 had nationalised the country’s land and natural resources, putting it on a collision course with U.S. companies and landowners.

Others still were energised by the global repercussions of the Russian Revolution. This, of course, included several brand-new communist parties across the region. But at the time, many others in Latin America saw the Bolsheviks as part of a global anti-colonial wave.

Mexico City as an activist hub

My book explores the key role Mexico City played as a gathering point for these different political tendencies.

They included groups ranging from Mexican peasant leagues to the American Popular Revolutionary Alliance, an anti-imperialist movement formed by Peruvian exiles. Many of these organisations converged under the umbrella of the Anti-Imperialist League of the Americas. Founded in Mexico City in 1925, it soon had chapters in a dozen more countries across the region.

Between them, these movements brought into focus the novel features of U.S. power. As the Cuban student leader and communist Julio Antonio Mella saw it in 1925 – at a time when his native country was highly dependent on the U.S. but formally sovereign – the U.S. was distinct. Unlike European empires, it largely refrained from direct control of territories, though it had pressed the Cubans to include in their 1901

constitution a provision allowing it to intervene in the island at will.

In Mella’s view, the U.S. was clearly an empire, one that mainly exercised its dominance through commercial or financial pressures. For him, the dollar and Wall Street were as central to U.S. power as the halls of government in Washington, DC.

For Ricardo Paredes, an Ecuadorean doctor who founded the country’s Socialist Party in 1926, a new term was required to capture Latin American countries’ contradictory position. Formally sovereign, they were not colonies as such. Yet they were economically and politically subordinated to Washington and Wall Street – “dependent countries,” as he phrased it in 1928.

For the Peruvian poet Magda Portal, a leading member of the anti-imperialist American Popular Revolutionary Alliance, U.S. dominance played out differently in different parts of Latin America.

In a series of lectures she gave in Puerto Rico and the Dominican Republic in 1929, Portal divided the region into zones. While countries such as Argentina or Brazil were mainly sites for U.S. investment, Mexico and the Caribbean were regularly subjected to U.S. military force. Or, as Portal put it, “Here imperialism wears no disguise.”

Portal concluded her lectures with a phrase that combined her analysis of U.S. dominance with a resonant appeal for unity: “We have a single and great enemy; let us form a single and great union.”

United States of resistance?

Yet while there was much Latin American anti-imperialist thinkers could agree on, there were also profound divergences between them. This included questions of strategy as well as issues of principle. What role should different classes play in their movement? How radical a transformation of society were they

pushing for? And what kind of state should emerge from it?

Over time, these differences turned into deep rifts that pitted revolutionaries against democratic reformists, internationalists against nationalists, and pro-Soviets against anti-communists. These disagreements played an important role in Latin American politics over the rest of the century. While many of these rifts became especially prominent during the Cold War, they developed out of earlier divisions over how best to counter U.S. dominance.

The anti-imperialist upsurge of the 1920s and ’30s was formative for a generation of Latin American radicals. Several of those who entered political life during these years went on to play key roles in major events of the 20th century. Raúl Roa, for example, who served as foreign secretary for Cuba’s revolutionary government from 1959 to 1976, was first politicised in the island’s anti-imperialist movement of the 1920s.

The men and women whose political visions were formed in the interwar period carried those ideals forward into the Cold War era. In important ways, the 1920s and 1930s laid vital groundwork for later and better-known radical movements.

Past is, of course, not always prologue. It is impossible to predict what the long-term consequences of current U.S. policy in Latin America will be, especially given the rightward tilt that is currently unfolding across the region.

But looking at the region’s anti-imperialist traditions does point to one possible outcome: The U.S.’s newly aggressive stance will, sooner rather than later, fuel a resurgence of anti-imperialist sentiment as the organising principle for a new generation of activists. (Tony Wood is Assistant Professor of History, Modern Latin America, University of Colorado Boulder. This article is republished from *The Conversation*)

THE GIST

▼ The approach resembles an older pattern of U.S. policy, justified by the Roosevelt Corollary and the exercise of an “international police power”.

▼ Across Latin America, movements from student organisations, labour unions, and leftist political parties put forward sharp critiques of U.S. power.

▼ Over time, deep divergences over strategy and principle pitted revolutionaries against democratic reformists, shaping politics in the region.

